

UPPSALA UNIVERSITY



MASTER'S THESIS

Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate

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1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Brief Overview

Through this thesis project, I apply transformative game design theory and best practices to create a new competitive debating format. This research employs Research through Design (RtD) methodology to develop and playtest an alternative debate format that addresses what I believe to be systematic problems in widely-used formats, particularly World Schools and British Parliamentary debate.

1.2 Motivation

I approach this research as a complete community member with 15 years of experience in competitive debate across multiple roles: debater, judge, coach, and organizer. This insider perspective informs my reformist motivation to improve formats that have both shaped and limited the community I value. I believe debate is a class of role-playing games with immense transformative potential, yet the design of major formats retains decades-old flaws, with game design theories and practices entirely absent from attempts to improve them.

1.3 Problem Statement

Although a very diverse range of debate formats are played all over the world, the practice seen in other games of iterative improvement of the game based on discoveries in game design is entirely absent, most formats being deeply calcified. Their competitive communities evolve new "metas", modes of play and interpretations of rules, without game design supervision. These are poised to lead, in time, to a pattern of accepting instead of solving the issues in the design of these formats. For example, based on my fifteen years of observation, participation, and informal conversations with fellow practitioners, I believe and hypothesize that the two most popular debate formats, World Schools and British Parliamentary, whose communities in Europe are deeply intertwined, exhibit the following problematic tendencies:

First, they seem to push debaters towards value convergence, an exclusionary and self-righteous holding of the same beliefs, potentially causing them to become less tolerant of people with different values and diminishing their ability to convince people from different backgrounds. Second, they appear to teach debaters to speak very fast and with extreme information density, which could diminish their ability to meaningfully support their positions to people not trained as debate judges. Third, in my opinion they push communities towards competitive hierarchical behavior that undermines psychological safety.

These observations, while grounded in extensive practitioner experience, have not been systematically validated through empirical research and this thesis does not intend to comprehensively prove them, although a later section will present their echoes in literature.

1.4 Research Question

How can the application of transformative game design theory inform the creation of a competitive debate format that manages to elevate its transformative potential (improved

critical thinking, improved discourse, self empowerment etc) by addressing the issues of value convergence, discourse speed and community hierarchy?

This question decomposes in two: can a method of applying said theory to this problem be described and demonstrated? and does that method yield expected results?

1.5 Scope and Limitations

This thesis aims to demonstrate proof of concept: that alternative debate formats can be systematically designed to address problems, and that such designs produce observable and articulable differences in participant experience. In particular it attempts to demonstrate, through behavioral observations and participant-reported experiences collected across five evaluation fields (engagement and appeal, productive pressure, growth direction, community dynamics, and epistemic humility), that a debate format grounded in transformative game design theory can produce clues of meaningful change without sacrificing the intellectual challenge or communal value of the activity.

The thesis does not aim to produce robust claims about long-term educational efficacy or entertainment value, as such claims would require longitudinal studies with larger samples than a master's thesis permits. Its main contribution to knowledge is the simple proof that debate formats can be designed better if looked at as roleplaying games.

2 BACKGROUND AND LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Topic Overview

2.2 Debate as Transformative Game

Academic debate formats are games. Following Salen and Zimmerman (2004), a game is a system in which players engage in artificial conflict, defined by rules, resulting in a quantifiable outcome. Academic debate satisfies all criteria: rules, participants, winners, losers, tournaments, and scoring systems. Alfred Snider, whose school of debate of training I was privileged in being apprenticed in, through his 1982 doctoral dissertation at the University of Kansas, along with his subsequent publication (Snider, 1984), established the scholarly foundation for viewing debate as a game while documenting its educational benefits.

But what makes a game *transformative*? Bowman et al. (2025) conceptualize transformative role-playing games as those intentionally designed to encourage personal and social change arising from play. For transformation to occur, this change must expand beyond the bounds of the original experience and integrate into the participant's daily frames of reality and identity. By this standard, a game is truly transformative not merely when participants report enjoyment or in-game learning, but when the experience produces lasting changes in cognition, behavior, or self-concept. The question for academic debate, then, is whether it meets this threshold.

Forensics pedagogy documents debate's transformative potential across several domains that satisfy this criterion. The most extensively studied is critical thinking: debaters develop the ability to recognize stated and unstated assumptions, evaluate causal inferences, and as-

sess the validity of arguments (Colbert, 1995/2002; Hill, 1993/2002). Beyond cognitive gains, debate serves as a vehicle for empowerment, particularly for previously “silenced student populations” who develop their own voice through the activity (Snider, 2003). The activity cultivates what Hicks (1998/2002a) calls a “democratic ethos”: the capacity to justify convictions in public, respect minority views, and evaluate opposing arguments critically. Oral communication proficiency develops through audience adaptation, where students learn to analyze listeners’ beliefs and norms to frame compelling narratives (Cirlin, 1997/2002), while parliamentary formats foster extemporaneous thinking and speaking (Whitmore, 1998/2002). Debate also functions as a “laboratory” for intensive research and information management (Broda-Bahm, 2002), with the intensity of high-level preparation frequently compared to master’s thesis work (Combs, 2002a). Finally, debate provides a socialization mechanism, integrating students into a sub-culture with specialized language that enhances their sense of belonging to an intellectual community (Cirlin, 1997/2002; Kargacin, 1998/2002). Crucially, these effects are not confined to the debate round itself. The above scholarly works state that they transfer into participants’ academic performance, professional communication, and civic engagement, satisfying the criterion of transformation beyond the game.

Empirical research substantiates these claims. Allen et al. (1999) conducted a meta-analysis finding a significant positive relationship between forensics participation and critical thinking gains (longitudinal $r = .18$), with forensics demonstrating the largest effect among communication activities studied. At the individual study level, Colbert (1987) found significant critical thinking gains in debaters relative to non-debaters over a full academic year ($F = 31.77, p < .001$).

Beyond critical thinking, debate participation correlates with substantial academic outcomes. Mezuk (2009) found Chicago Debate League participants were 70% more likely to graduate and three times less likely to drop out than comparable non-participants, with gains concentrated among the lowest-performing students at baseline.

Forensics scholars have proposed several theoretical frameworks to explain how debate produces these transformative effects, each grounded in established learning theory. At the cognitive level, Colbert (1995/2002) argues that critical thinking develops through what he calls “intellectual disequilibrium,” a concept rooted in Piaget’s constructivism, where confrontation with opposing positions forces learners to restructure their mental models rather than simply absorb new information. Debate’s adversarial structure ensures this confrontation is unavoidable: a debater cannot ignore the opposing case but must engage with it directly, producing the cognitive conflict that drives accommodation. At the communicative level, Cirlin (1997/2002) draws on Richard Weaver’s rhetorical theory to show that debate develops persuasive skill through audience adaptation: debaters must continuously analyze their listeners’ beliefs and norms to construct compelling narratives, a practice that transfers to communication contexts outside the activity. At the social level, Cirlin provides a sociological account of how participation integrates students into a discourse community with shared analytical vocabulary and norms of evidence evaluation. This linguistic socialization, which Cirlin describes through Weaver’s concept of “sermonic” language, reshapes how participants perceive and engage with arguments in ordinary life. At the civic level, Hicks (1998/2002a) argues, drawing on Rawls’s ideal of public reason, that debate cultivates a “democratic ethos”: the disposition to justify convictions through publicly accessible reasoning, to respect minority views, and to evaluate opposing arguments on their merits. Drawing

these threads together, Bellon (2000) synthesized evidence from competitive forensics, communication pedagogy, and educational psychology, including research on active learning and the social construction of knowledge, to argue that debate is a uniquely effective pedagogical tool precisely because it engages all of these levels simultaneously. However, these forensics-specific frameworks have not been connected to broader theories of experiential and transformative learning.

Although forensics pedagogy has successfully documented debate’s transformative effects and proposed explanatory mechanisms, I have yet to find any paper that analyzes major debate formats from a game design perspective or presents academic debating as a role-playing game, though Bowman (2014) acknowledges related pedagogical approaches such as process drama, classroom debates and simulation as role-playing games. Transformative role-playing game theory provides sophisticated conceptual tools for understanding how structured play produces personal change, yet these have not been applied to competitive debate. Addressing this gap in literature, applying game design lenses and expertise to the analysis and improvement of debate formats, is the main contribution to knowledge that I seek to start making through this paper.

2.3 Debate as Role-Playing Game

In the World Schools format, the one I will most focus on in this paper, in every debate there are two teams which receive a motion (e.g., “This House Would legalize the possession of drugs”). Teams are randomly assigned to opposite sides: Proposition/Government or Opposition. They deliver alternating speeches as if they were individuals supporting or opposing the motion. Judges listen as someone with no opinion on the motion, expert in debate rules, and averagely informed, deciding who most convinced the character they role-play. The debate ends with the judge ruling who won, explaining their decision and then offering feedback for improvement to the teams.

Understanding debate’s relationship to role-playing games requires first establishing what role-playing games are and where debate fits among related practices. As Zagal and Deterding (2024) observe, defining role-playing games is notoriously contentious, with scholars, designers, and practitioners disagreeing across forms, styles, and communities. However, certain characteristics commonly recur: role-playing games are play activities revolving around the rule-structured creation and enactment of characters in a fictional world, where players define and pursue their own goals with considerable choice in what actions they can attempt (Zagal & Deterding, 2024). Bowman et al. (2025) offer a functional definition: analog role-playing games are “co-creative experiences in which participants immerse into fictional characters and realities for a bounded period of time and improvise through spontaneous, emergent playfulness” (p. 16). Debate fits both these definitions as they place fictional defenders of positions in a fictional world in which a crucial decision will be taken based on their discourse, which they have broad choice in how they attempt. The experience is created by all participants together, the debate is time-bound and everything is playfully (it is a game afterall) improvised.

Transformative game design literature explicitly positions debate among “cousin forms” of analog role-playing games (Bowman, 2014; Bowman et al., 2025), alongside simulations, educational role-playing, improv theatre, and psychodrama. The distinction rests not on the

act of role-playing itself, which is much the same regardless of community, but on practices, norms, and innovations developing within each community. For the analytical purpose of usefully employing the body of theory developed to explain how and how better can role-playing games harness positive transformative energies, this is already enough to justify the following section. As will be later revealed, most of the theory developed within the Nordic larp tradition explains processes common to all role-playing activities. Going even further however, competitive debate occupies an unusual position among these cousin forms, one that warrants closer examination. While debate is indeed used in educational contexts, it differs fundamentally from close cousins such as work simulations or classroom exercises in ways that bring it closer to analog role-playing games proper. Three theoretical dimensions illuminate this proximity: the depth of character immersion, the strength of alibi, and the leisure-community dimension.

First, regarding immersion: As opposed to work simulations or boardgames, debate requires players to genuinely inhabit an epistemic stance, constructing and defending arguments as if they believed them. This process of active perspective-taking requires what Bowman (2010) describes as adopting a theory of mind, thinking “as if” one were someone else in a unique set of circumstances (p. 57). The debater must anticipate objections, identify weaknesses, and respond to challenges as someone who holds the assigned position, a cognitive demand that approaches the immersion into character central to role-playing games. As Seo (2022) observes, “the moment one received a motion, one adopted the mindset of a person who was completely convinced of that point of view. One clung to this feeling of absolute conviction to make arguments, sink objections, and display passion” (p. 222). Rules also encourage speaking passionately: Snider (1999) instructs debaters to speak “with energy, enthusiasm, commitment, and variety” and to “act like you care about the arguments” (p. 65). I myself felt, and many colleague debaters also expressed, how the extreme cognitive load that performance in debate demands is incompatible with not fully assuming for the duration of the debate the opinion demanded by the motion, only to then discard it easily in time for the next debate (especially in a competition). Seo corroborates this from the inside: “Midspeech, a speaker rarely experiences the physical strain of thinking so damn hard. The adrenaline induced a mental foggiess that numbed the hard edges of experience” (p. 159). This passionate delivery, especially in the context of such extreme cognitive load, is difficult to sustain through meta-cognitive simulation alone. Affective role-assumption becomes the efficient path, organically eliciting rather than faking the emotions expressed.

Bowman (2010) identifies nine types of relationships between players and characters, including the “Fragmented Self,” where a facet of the player’s personality or interests becomes magnified into a central character trait. Debate characters fit this framework: they represent fragmented selves whose defining feature is epistemic commitment to a particular position. The debater role-plays as someone who believes the motion should pass or fail, adopting that argumentative perspective as the character’s core identity. They find in themselves beliefs they can hold that support the position and banish from thought all other, focusing on a fragment of their identity.

Second, regarding alibi: this concept describes how game participants can act with lessened social consequences, encouraging risk-taking and willingness to fail (Deterding, 2017). Debate provides robust alibi through its competitive frame. Because debate is “just a game,” debaters can advance positions they might not advocate publicly and explore uncomfortable

arguments. Seo (2022) captures this vividly: the random assignment of sides provided a paradoxical “sense of freedom,” allowing him to “flirt with ideas, unencumbered by expectations of consistency or deep conviction” (p. 20). Work simulations do not offer that, as the situational enactment they demand does not require holding specific beliefs, which are a strong coordinate of identity. This enables the identity experimentation that Bowman et al. (2025) identify as central to transformational containers. It is important to accept that debate however, as all competitive games, does require debaters to perform at and judges them by their peak intellectual ability, not offering them alibi to fail. I would argue however that many TTRPGs and boffer LARPs are designed requiring players to perform intellectually, and that roleplayers within certain communities feel pressure to display acting ability and ability to deeply emotionally immerse. In mainstream North American boffer LARPs, for instance, players who “break game” risk derision or ostracism (Brown, 2016), while in Nordic larp communities, immersion into character is often treated as an indicator of success, with its absence experienced as personal failure (Harder, 2018; Pohjola, 2015). They all however offer players alibi to hold a different identity. Alibi to fail is not essential to a roleplaying game, but alibi to assume the mantle of a character is. On that metric, debate offers players a very strong alibi to embody a character with deeply different opinions from their own: what Seo describes as tracing “the steps of how a sensible person (us!) could arrive at conclusions that might otherwise have seemed alien” (p. 224).

Third, regarding the leisure-community dimension: competitive debate possesses passionate discourse communities distinguishing role-playing games from cousin forms. The World Schools and British Parliamentary circuits encompass hundreds of competitions. Debaters participate voluntarily, often for decades; they develop specialized terminology, shared references, and community norms; they attend tournaments analogous to gaming conventions. The activity is often pursued for its intrinsic satisfactions, not merely as preparation for external goal. This leisure dimension, combined with the vibrant discourse community, positions competitive debate closer to role-playing games than to the educational simulations with which it shares surface similarities.

Furthermore, evidence for debate’s role-playing dimension appears throughout its practice. Experienced coaches regularly employ explicit role-playing techniques during preparation, asking debaters to “become” stakeholders affected by policies. Furthermore, debate ethos as I witnessed it is summoned through traditions that explicitly stage parliamentary fiction: bench-pounding, heckling, Points of Information delivered as if holding onto wigs. The format performs a fiction of parliamentary deliberation, with debaters and judges alike participating in theatrical conventions inherited from eighteenth-century British debate culture.

Genuine differences between debate and games that are more traditionally seen as analogue role-playing games, such as Dungeons and Dragons, are undeniable: debate lacks the narrative worldbuilding, the character backstories, and the extended campaign structures of tabletop or live-action role-playing. But it is important to recognize that debate’s role-playing operates through the same psychological mechanisms and this justifies applying the substantial body of transformative game design scholarship to understand how debate produces its educational effects and, more importantly, how design choices might enhance or undermine those effects.

2.4 Literature Review of Format Critiques

The usefulness of applying transformative game design theory to attempt solving the problems of current debate formats comes also from the apparent failure of current scholarly works in the same endeavor. The largest body of work that analyzes debate as an educational tool is that of forensics pedagogy. This centers around the more predominant formats played in the US (especially American Policy). I will thus focus on reviewing what literature was written that echoes the problems I set out to solve and that forms arguments that are also applicable to the formats that I seek to improve (especially the World Schools format).

2.4.1 The Technical-Public Sphere Tension

A fundamental critique pervading the literature concerns the evolution of debate formats away from public sphere accessibility toward technical sphere insularity. Combs (2002b) documents how both NDT (National Debate Tournament) and CEDA (Cross Examination Debate Association) have evolved into technical sphere activities characterized by: expert-level topic knowledge, speaking rates exceeding what most listeners can process, sophisticated analytical models inaccessible to non-specialists, heavy reliance on extensive note-taking, and specially trained judges.

2.4.2 Value Convergence and Ideological Homogenization

The “closed system” dynamic described by Harris and Smith, cited in Combs (2002b), creates conditions conducive to value convergence. In academic debate, tournament practices are insulated from external feedback and where judges who deviate from community norms are “effectively excluded from the system much like the human system rejects certain bacteria” (Combs, 2002b, p. 40). This dynamic may cultivate shared assumptions that, while facilitating intra-community communication, potentially diminish debaters’ capacity to engage persuasively with those holding different values.

Crenshaw’s work on feminism in debate, cited by McGee (2002), illustrates how “argument borrowing” can lead to reductionist treatment of complex intellectual traditions. Debaters observe which arguments succeed in out-rounds, then adopt those lines of reasoning for their strategic value rather than out of genuine engagement with the underlying ideas, producing superficial understanding and reduced capacity for authentic cross-ideological dialogue.

2.4.3 Delivery Practices and Communicative Capacity

Colbert, cited in Combs (2002b), found that average CEDA debaters spoke at approximately 237 words per minute, while NDT finalists averaged 284 words per minute, with some exceeding 300 words per minute, rates that “greatly exceed what is considered optimal for normal speaking” (Combs, 2002b, p. 36).

While World Schools and British Parliamentary formats explicitly discourage talking fast through style-based evaluation, similar pressures toward information density exist. In my observation, this occurs because these formats evaluate on two officially co-equal axes—Style

(or Manner) and Content (or Matter)—yet increasing information density improves argumentative quality (more points addressed, more rebuttal, more nuance) while simultaneously reducing intelligibility and persuasive clarity. Because debate operates in an academic setting where the analysis of argumentative quality is perceived as more objective and measurable than the assessment of style, the competitive meta gradually shifts toward privileging Content over Style, even though the evaluation rubric formally treats them as equally important. The result is that the skills developed may not transfer to contexts without expert judges. The difficulty to solve this is also captured in literature. (Hicks, 2002b) treats the difficulty of defining for what type of audience should debaters make themselves persuasive, comparing Weiss (2002)’s “audience standard” (being understandable to a regular audience) to his “ideal of public reason” (being understandable to the perfect rational listener), presenting how some educational value is lost either way.

2.4.4 Hierarchical Dynamics and Psychological Safety

In this issue I have observed forensics pedagogy literature is thinnest, yet several authors recognize the risk. Snider (1999) addresses safety and ethics in his Code of the Debate, and in his later practical guide warns organizers to “avoid a counterproductive rigid and hierarchical organization,” noting “I’ve seen groups die when they let ego and status get in the way” (Snider, 2014, p. 36). The International Debate Education Association’s ethics guide for coaches and youth workers similarly acknowledges the “unbalanced power dynamic” inherent in coach-student relationships, compounded by the fact that “older debaters often mentor younger teams” and thus occupy dual roles of peer and authority figure (International Debate Education Association, 2024). Riley and Hollihan further suggest that approximately three years of debate experience are required to compete effectively on the national circuit, effectively excluding students without extensive preparation and reinforcing experience-based hierarchies (Combs, 2002b, p. 38).

The mechanism behind these dynamics is illuminated by recent research. Prus and Sikora (2025), citing Simon et al. (2020), note that “people placed in competitive intellectual situations tend to develop an adversarial mindset” characterized by myside bias and otherside bias, distorting cognitive appraisal of the issues being debated. They identify competitive debate’s “most crucial weakness”: its rules “do not allow for saying to the opponent: ‘You are right, I was wrong’” instead training debaters to listen for omissions and inaccuracies rather than for understanding (Prus & Sikora, 2025, p. 1474). When win-loss records become the primary measure of status within these hermetic communities, the adversarial structure produces natural hierarchies in which winning debaters gain social authority while losing debaters are marginalized, reinforcing competitive pressure at the expense of collaborative learning.

2.5 Gap Identification

This literature review reveals a significant gap. Forensics pedagogy has established debate’s educational benefits and identified tensions, but has not systematically applied game design frameworks to analyze how specific format mechanics produce specific effects. Transformative role-playing game theory provides sophisticated tools for understanding how structured play

produces personal change, but has not been applied to competitive debate. Addressing this gap is a central contribution of this thesis.

3 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This section develops an integrated framework synthesizing transformative role-playing game theory, learning theory, and procedural rhetoric to explain debate’s transformative mechanisms and guide design decisions.

3.1 Core Theoretical Constructs

3.1.1 The Transformational Container

The concept of the transformational container originates in the psychoanalytic work of Winnicott (1960) and was adapted to role-playing game theory by Bowman and Hugaas (2021). It describes a bounded space in which consent is emphasized, boundaries are established, and content is calibrated to maintain psychological safety, enabling participants to take risks and experiment with new ways of being (Baird & Bowman, 2022; Bowman & Hugaas, 2021; Bowman et al., 2025). The transformational container builds upon but extends Huizinga (1958)’s concept of the “magic circle”: whereas all games can be said to possess a magic circle demarcating play from ordinary life, a transformational container additionally requires explicit goals, safety structures, and community support oriented toward lasting personal change (Bowman et al., 2025). I argue that debate, in its existing forms, already constitutes a partially-realized transformational container. The format’s explicit rules and conventions (speaking times, turn order, permissible modes of engagement) establish boundaries that demarcate the debate encounter from ordinary social interaction, much as ritual framing guides participants into a liminal space (Bowman et al., 2025). Within these boundaries, the competitive frame provides what Deterding (2017) terms *alibi*: because side allocation is typically random and the activity is understood as a game, the reason a debater advances a given position is “I was assigned this side,” not “I personally believe this.” This deflection of inference from displayed behavior to the game’s structure reduces social risk, granting participants permission to explore unfamiliar arguments, adopt perspectives they might not publicly endorse, and fail without lasting reputational consequences. The judge, meanwhile, functions as the containing authority analogous to the facilitator in transformative game design (Bowman et al., 2025): a figure who maintains the rules, calibrates the encounter through feedback, and structures the post-round evaluation that helps participants process the experience. However, as Bowman et al. (2025) caution, a container’s effectiveness is not guaranteed by its mere existence; communities that fail to support participants may interrupt transformative processes. If competitive pressures become so intense that tournament success conflates with personal worth, the alibi weakens as participants can no longer treat debate as “just a game” and the container’s transformational potential erodes.

3.1.2 Bleed as Transformative Mechanism

Following Hugaas (2024), bleed describes the bidirectional spillover of psychological contents between player and character (or in debate, between the debater and their assigned position). This concept is crucial for understanding how debate produces its educational effects. Leonard and Thurman (2018), drawing on Lankoski and Järvelä (2012)’s grounded cognition framework, provide neuroscientific grounding for bleed: embodied cognition means that inhabiting a role activates neuropsychological processes that do not fully distinguish fictional from real experience, with hormonal responses associated with trust and social bonding operating in character-mediated interactions just as they do in ordinary life. Moreover, compartmentalizing in-character reactions requires self-regulatory control, a limited resource that depletes during sustained effortful performance. Applied to debate, this framework suggests that extended rounds of inhabiting an assigned position gradually erode the cognitive separation between debater and debater-character, helping explain why sustained debate practice can produce lasting attitudinal shifts.

Memetic bleed, the transfer of ideas and perspectives, explains how debaters should develop what I call epistemic humility: an attitude of skepticism towards one’s own opinions, being open to understand the beliefs of others and to accept them as valid, essentially the opposite of value convergence. First of all through the very direct memetic bleed of the opinions of the role played in a debate towards the debater, arguments which can be summoned again outside of the debate. But more than that, after years of arguing for positions contrary to their beliefs, debaters bleed into accepting that reasonable people can formulate opposing views, that anything can be argued convincingly, and that argumentative power does not equate with being right. This mechanism provides a theoretical account of what forensics scholars have documented empirically: Colbert’s “intellectual disequilibrium” (Colbert, 1995/2002), the cognitive conflict produced by engaging with opposing positions, describes the trigger that opens the channel for memetic bleed, while the “democratic ethos” that Hicks (1998/2002a) identifies as debate’s civic outcome is the intended result of that bleed integrating into the debater’s empowered attitude.

This bleed of a certain humble attitude connects to Bogost (2007) concept of procedural rhetoric. Bogost argues that every game, though its systems and rules, reflects a certain world-view, that players in time may be persuaded of. The rules of debate inherently postulate that anyone can support anything and that through dialectic processes of presenting arguments for and against, not truth is reached, but a showcase of who is more capable in argument (as two opposite decisions could be taken in two different rounds on the same motion). Thus experienced debaters ideally learn to acknowledge how there may be much truth in the points made also by the less skilled in argument.

Procedural bleed, the transfer of physical abilities and habits, explains skill development. The rhetorical habits, speaking patterns, and argumentative reflexes developed through competition bleed into debaters’ ordinary communication, producing the documented improvements in public speaking and critical thinking. Cirlin (1997/2002)’s account of how debaters develop persuasive skill through audience adaptation (outlined above as learning to analyze listeners’ beliefs and norms to construct compelling narratives) describes precisely this form of procedural bleed and its transfer beyond the activity.

Emancipatory bleed (Kemper, 2017, 2020) explains debate’s particular power for stu-

dents from marginalized backgrounds. For students where eloquent public speaking was not modeled, debate provides a transformational container (Bowman & Hugaas, 2021) to discover and develop their voice. Being taken seriously as intellectuals, having ideas weighed on merits rather than dismissed based on identity, produces lasting changes in self-concept and capability. Snider (2003)’s documentation of debate empowering previously “silenced student populations” through Urban Debate Leagues provides empirical evidence for this form of bleed in competitive debate contexts.

3.1.3 Zone of Proximal Development and Scaffolded Learning

Vygotsky (1978) zone of proximal development explains how debate creates naturally occurring scaffolding: power-pairing ensures challenges remain within the zone where growth occurs, while judges provide guided instruction through post-debate feedback. The debate cycle naturally embodies Kolb (1984) experiential learning model, with the debrief, which Crookall (2014) and Daniau (2016) identify as essential to transformation, built into debate through the oral critique. This scaffolding explains why the “intellectual disequilibrium” that Colbert (1995/2002) identifies as debate’s cognitive engine produces growth rather than frustration: coaching, graduated competition, and structured feedback keep the cognitive challenge within the zone where productive accommodation occurs.

3.2 Reframing Forensics Pedagogy Critiques through Transformative Game Design

The critiques identified within forensics pedagogy, echoing the issues identified during the problem statement, can be productively reframed through the theoretical mechanisms of transformative game design, illuminating not only why these problems occur but also suggesting design-based interventions.

3.2.1 Value Convergence as Corrupted Memetic Bleed

What I coined as value convergence can be seen as a failure in memetic bleed. The intended transformative outcome of debate is epistemic humility. However, memetic bleed is mediated by judges, creating vulnerability to what I term *evaluative bleed-in*. Judges role-play as neutral arbiters, but this role is cognitively demanding and vaguely specified. When judges share common backgrounds, their collective bleed-in produces systematic biases.

Following Bowman et al. (2025), the container’s effectiveness requires psychological safety for all participants, including judges. When judges face social consequences for heterodox opinions that deviate from “emancipatory rhetoric” community consensus, the alibi protecting experimental judgment erodes. What bleeds into debaters is the community’s strategic equilibrium rather than appreciation for intellectual diversity. Debaters, optimizing for competitive success, do “argument borrowing”, adapting strategically: arguments that succeed in elimination rounds or from high-status debaters become templates, and approaches aligned with perceived values propagate. This in time leads to community members to see said values as the only acceptable ones, integrating them in their identity.

Design interventions might therefore diversify audiences debaters must persuade, strengthen judge alibi through structural features, and explicitly distinguish in debriefing between “what won this debate” and “what constitutes good reasoning.”

3.2.2 Information Density and Misaligned Procedural Bleed

The critique of information-dense speaking represents misalignment in procedural bleed. When formats reward rapid delivery optimized for expert judges, debaters develop procedural habits adapted to highly specific audiences. The skills that bleed out are real but narrowly optimized, representing failure of transfer.

Design interventions might include evaluation criteria rewarding accessibility alongside substance, or judging paradigms simulating general audiences. By constructing vivid characters for judges to role-play, the bleed-in from character to judge can itself become memetic, the judge taking on the character’s understanding while maintaining expert-level rule comprehension.

3.2.3 Competitive Pressure and the Compromised Container

When competitive pressures become overwhelming, when tournament success determines status and self-worth, the alibi enabling transformation erodes. Participants can no longer treat debate as “just a game” because stakes have become too real. Bowman (2013) documents social conflict within role-playing communities arising from power differentials between facilitators and players, competitive play dynamics, creative agenda disputes, and unprocessed bleed. These patterns parallel competitive debate: power differentials map onto hierarchies between experienced and novice debaters, competitive play produces status systems based on tournament success, and creative agenda disputes manifest as exclusion of those whose approach does not conform to community norms.

This compromise cascades through other mechanisms. Emancipatory bleed requires a container where being taken seriously is possible; rigid hierarchies block this for those positioned as subordinate. The zone of proximal development requires calibrated challenges; competitive anxiety may prevent productive struggle or reflective observation.

Design interventions might distribute status more broadly, emphasize growth over victory, strengthen alibi by making explicit the distinction between game performance and personal worth, and incorporate safety practices adapted from larp design (Bowman et al., 2025).

4 METHODS

4.1 Design Philosophy

This research employs Research through Design (RtD) as primary methodological framework. RtD positions the design process itself as inquiry, where knowledge emerges through making and iterating upon designed artifacts (Coulton & Hook, 2017; J. Zimmerman et al., 2007). The design process follows E. Zimmerman (2003) iterative methodology, treating play as research. Each playtest generates data informing subsequent decisions, creating a spiral of refined understanding.

4.2 Development Process

Development unfolded through several phases. In the generation phase, I explored potential mechanics addressing theoretically-identified problems through brainstorming and design conversations with debate and game-design peers. In the critical scrutiny phase, I evaluated whether candidate designs congruently addressed problems without introducing new difficulties (e.g., judge cognitive load, time limitations), using my own game design judgment and the theoretical framework as evaluation criteria. In the validation phase, surviving elements underwent testing within observed small pilot playtests followed each by a post-session debrief. In the critical analysis phase I synthesized relevant notes on the design based on my observations and opinions expressed during the debrief.

The process completed three iterative cycles (each critical analysis phase sourcing a new generation phase). The first playtest (one debate) was held in March 2026. A second design iteration was drafted based on its findings. The second playtest was conducted in April 2026 with seven veteran debaters in a familiar informal setting, yielding a third design iteration. Both sessions are documented in Annexes A–G.

4.3 Research Methods

For analyzing the quality of the design, two playtests were organized. Each took about 4 hours and included a set of workshops introducing the format’s rules and roles (deliberately omitting any mention of its theoretical underpinnings or design goals to avoid demand characteristics), the debate itself, and the group debrief. During these sessions the research methods used were participant observation and semi-structured post-session group debriefs, followed by qualitative data analysis.

4.3.1 Participant Observation

Following Baker (2006), I adopted a participant-as-observer role during both playtest sessions. My researcher status was known to participants, and I participated actively in both sessions to obtain firsthand understanding, serving as facilitator during workshops and debriefs and as a debater during the debate itself.

Observation focused on overall debate flow and more granularly on behaviors relevant to entertainment value, rule legibility and adherence ease, and elements distinct from standard formats, judging whether these indicate positive or negative tendencies vis-à-vis identified problems and the theoretical framework’s predictions.

Informed by the advice of Spradley (1980), I recorded field notes in two phases: condensed and expanded. Condensed notes, taken during debates, captured key moments, quotations, and behavioral observations using a brief written observation template. Expanded notes, written within 24 hours of the sessions, elaborated, added contextual observations, and recorded analytical reflections. Both sessions were audio-recorded with participant consent to enable field note verification and capture verbal content not fully documented in real-time.

4.3.2 Participants

Debaters were recruited for the first session with the aid of ARDOR Muntenia, the NGO managing the debate community in Bucharest, and the session was held as part of a weekend meeting of the Jean Monnet highschool debate club. It was held with 8 senior debaters aged 18 to 20. Roles within the debate were assigned randomly. The second session was organized through personal contacts: participants were veteran debaters known to the researcher, recruited informally. The debate was held with 7 senior debaters aged 28 to 38, and roles within the debate were assigned randomly.

The majority of Romanian debaters are minors. Ideally, the study would involve minor participants, but ethical guidelines pushed toward this strategy as best alternative. Both sessions used convenience sampling: the first through an NGO-affiliated club event, the second through personal contacts, appropriate for proof-of-concept RtD but not representative. The significant age and life-experience gap between cohorts is acknowledged as limiting the evidential weight of cross-session consistency.

4.3.3 Post-Session Debriefs

Semi-structured group debriefs complemented observation. After each play session an approximately one-hour conversation was held with each playtest’s participants together: the researcher introduced a set of pre-planned open questions derived from the theoretical predictions (Annex C), but allowed the conversation to develop organically, following participant-introduced threads and encouraging elaboration on emergent themes. Both sessions were audio-recorded with participants’ consent. As an acknowledged limitation of group format, social conformity effects and the influence of dominant voices cannot be fully eliminated; organic conversation development and active follow-up on quieter participants were used to partially mitigate this.

4.4 Data Analysis

Analysis follows a design-oriented evaluative approach. The primary purpose is not generating generalizable theory but informing ongoing design decisions and articulating how the designed format produces experiences consistent with its design predictions, assessed against the researcher’s extensive observational experience of existing formats. This aligns with experimental game design methodology (Waern & Back, 2015), where design experimentation becomes research when “the aim is to understand something generic, some more fundamental aspect of game design.”

Before data collection, the five evaluation fields derived from the research question and theoretical framework, each corresponding to a specific effect the designed format is predicted to produce, were operationalized into a taxonomy of *potential clues*: specific observable behaviors or reported experiences that would count as evidence for or against each field’s prediction. Additional clue categories were created after data collection where I observed the taxonomy to not be comprehensive enough (these additions captured behaviors the taxonomy lacked vocabulary for, not reframings of anticipated clue types). Both positive clues (behaviors consistent with the format achieving its intended effect) and negative clues

(behaviors indicating a design gap or failure to achieve it) were specified at this stage. This pre-specification ensures the analysis remains responsive to disconfirming evidence rather than converging only on confirming observations. The complete taxonomy, reproduced in Annex I, thus defines in advance what would need to be observed to consider the format effective or ineffective in each field. The research subquestion of whether the format achieves its intended effects is answered field by field: the balance of clues found within a field constitutes evidence for or against its prediction, and the aggregate across all five fields answers the whole.

Between playtest sessions, rapid analysis of observation and debrief data focused on actionable insights: what mechanics worked and should be preserved, what did not work and caused confusion or disengagement, and what surprised me and suggested new opportunities. This treats playtesting as “play as research” (E. Zimmerman, 2003), because play emerges from rules as they are inhabited by participants in ways that cannot be fully predicted in advance: each session surfaces questions that were not part of the initial investigation and could not have been anticipated without actually playing. The design cycle is driven not by confirming prior expectations but by discovering what the design still needs to become.

After all playtest sessions were concluded, systematic analysis of field notes and session transcripts proceeded in four steps. First, both sources were read in full and individual clues were extracted: each specific behavior observed or participant statement made that could constitute evidence for any field’s prediction. Second, each clue was assigned to one of the pre-specified taxonomy categories in Annex I; where the taxonomy proved insufficient, new categories were created. Third, each clue was assessed for evidential strength using explicit criteria: behavioral evidence was weighted above self-report; unsolicited observations above responses to direct prompts; evidence consistent across both playtest sessions above single-session occurrences; and novel or different behaviors above continuities, which may reflect participants’ existing training rather than effects of the format (Lankoski & Björk, 2015). Fourth, the clues within each field were synthesized into a field-level judgment: the prediction was considered confirmed when positive clues outweighed negative ones in aggregate strength, held with caveats when evidence was mixed, and not confirmed when negative clues dominated or predicted positive clues were absent, with the meaningful absence of predicted negative clues treated as supporting evidence in all cases.

Together, these steps can demonstrate: (a) specific predicted effects of the format did or did not materialize at the behavioral or participant-report level; (b) specific mechanics appear connected to specific observed effects; and (c) observed effects align with the format’s intended design goals. They cannot demonstrate persistence, superiority, or generalizability, appropriate limitations for proof-of-concept Research through Design where contribution lies in demonstrating that systematic design can address identified problems and in articulating design principles meriting further investigation or usage. They also cannot eliminate the risk of motivated interpretation: all coding was performed by a single researcher who is also the format’s designer, with no inter-rater verification; the pre-specified taxonomy and reflexive notes are partial mitigations but not substitutes for independent coding.

4.5 Ethical Considerations

This research adheres to Uppsala University’s ethical guidelines for research involving human participants. All playtest participants were informed of the purpose and context, how data would be gathered, stored, and analyzed, both during and after recruitment. All were able to offer and retract consent, granularly or wholesale, to participation in every process part and to data being collected, stored, or used. Peers whose input was used in developing this format were informed of context and credited. All data is stored securely in encrypted Microsoft OneDrive offered by Uppsala University, separated by content type, and will be deleted once thesis development and presentation is complete. All data has been anonymized and is not publicly available.

To ensure psychological safety, the rigorous ethical standards imposed by the ARDOR Ethical Guide and ARDOR Trainer Safety Guide were followed. Debate topics avoided personal trauma topics and debaters were able to refuse to engage with motions. Debaters were able to talk to a third-party equity officer regarding emotional safety issues and report abusive or distressing behavior. During debates, all debaters were able to exit without explanation.

Beyond these, all participants had pre-session briefing and post-session debrief providing chances to address potential distressing elements before activity and discuss experience afterwards.

4.6 Positionality and Reflexivity

I approached this research as a complete community member (Adler & Adler, 1987), with fifteen years in competitive debate shaping not only my knowledge but my values, assumptions, and emotional investments. This creates several positionality challenges. *Insider knowledge* enables nuanced recognition of subtle format problems but risks normalizing issues I cannot perceive from within the community. *Structural circularity* is the most consequential: I authored the theoretical framework, designed the format to satisfy it, and then evaluated whether it did, predisposing every stage of the process toward confirmation, not only interpretation. *Disciplinary lens* poses a different risk: game design framing surfaces questions forensics scholarship would not, but may equally miss domain-specific considerations that lens cannot see. *Power dynamics* from my status as former Team Romania coach and successful debater may have shaped participant candor and debrief dynamics. *Acquaintance proximity* in the second session deepened rapport and observation access while amplifying social desirability and confirmation risks.

Several measures were taken to partially mitigate these biases. The pre-specified clue taxonomy locked evaluation criteria before data collection, limiting post-hoc rationalization of findings. Reflexive notes at the end of every playtest journal (Knott et al., 2022) actively sought disconfirming evidence. Awareness of power dynamics informed deliberate facilitation choices to encourage dissenting voices. However, no measure fully eliminates circularity in single-researcher RtD: the pre-specified taxonomy was itself designed by the researcher whose predictions it tests.

Taken together, these positions make this research inherently partial and interpretive in ways that cannot be controlled away. All findings should be read as design-informed evidence

rather than independent verification. Further method-specific limitations, including group debrief conformity effects, convenience sampling, and the absence of inter-rater verification, are noted in their respective subsections above.

5 DESIGN OF THE INSIDE OUT FORMAT

5.1 From Theory to Design

This chapter summarizes and theoretically justifies the Inside Out format, the output of the generation and critical scrutiny phases of the RtD process. The entire first-iteration ruleset is presented in full in Annex A, and annexes B–D present its chronological evolution. The following sections argue why each structural element exists and how it serves the theoretical objectives, both for the initial design decisions made prior to playtesting and for the two significant structural additions (not just refinements of existing elements) made in light of playtest.

5.2 Design Summary

Inside Out is a role-playing debate format for nine participants: eight debaters organised into four teams of two, and one Evaluator. Three teams, the **Value Defenders**, are each assigned one of three values held by a fictional named Subject. The fourth team, the **Subject team**, plays that person: a specific individual facing a genuine personal dilemma, whose role is not to win but to weigh the arguments they hear and reach a decision.

A debate round follows a structured sequence. The round starts with a set of Rolling In rituals. Then the three Value Defender teams deliver first speeches (**A1, B1, C1**) in turn, each arguing for their assigned value and proposing a concrete, self-constructed decision it recommends. The Subject team then delivers their own first speech (**S1**), committing to a preliminary decision and explaining which arguments have so far moved them and why. The Defenders then deliver second speeches (**A2, B2, C2**), responding to the Subject's preliminary position and refining their cases. Finally, the Subject delivers a closing synthesis (**S2**): they name the decision they have reached and explain, transparently, what arguments and values actually moved them.

A separate person, the **Evaluator**, does not judge or decide the winner. They observe the round, then award **commendations** — named recognitions for specific demonstrated skills — and deliver oral feedback oriented toward growth rather than competitive outcome. The round closes with **Rolling Out**: participants de-role, shake hands, and the Evaluator invites a brief, optional check on whether anything in the debate felt personally close to home.

Inside Out departs from the World Schools (WS) format in three structural ways: the **team structure and roles** (four teams with distinct functions, plus a separate Evaluator); the **shape of motions** (personal, circumstantial dilemmas specifying the Subject's context and values, rather than abstract propositions); and the **rituals and special speeches** (Rolling In/Out, the interstitial S1, and S2) that frame the debate as genuine deliberation rather than adversarial performance. The following sections justify each departure.

5.3 Design Rationale

Each structural choice in Inside Out traces to the theoretical framework’s diagnosis of how traditional formats produce corrupted bleed, misaligned skill transfer, and container compromise. This section justifies the format’s core design decisions.

5.3.1 Why Multiple Teams Defending Values?

Traditional formats position two teams in binary opposition, a structure whose procedural rhetoric (Bogost, 2007) teaches that every issue has exactly two sides. Inside Out replaces this with three Value Defender teams, each advocating for a different value held by the Subject. This restructuring addresses several identified problems simultaneously.

The multi-team structure produces a procedural rhetoric of complexity and humility: the format asserts through its rules that decisions involve balancing multiple legitimate human values, not choosing between right and wrong. This directly counters the corrupted memetic bleed driving value convergence by positioning value pluralism at the core of the conflict rather than treating it as a side effect of switch-side argumentation. Because what is assigned is a value rather than a policy position, the debater-character relationship is explicitly about inhabiting an identity facet (Bowman, 2010) rather than advocating an instrumental stance. This strengthens the alibi (Deterding, 2017) that protects the transformational container: the debater’s displayed behaviour is attributable to the character’s core commitments, not to the debater’s own beliefs, making perspective-taking the central mechanic. And because the Subject is a person with specific background, circumstances, and values rather than an abstract decision-maker, the motion reinforces that decisions are products of context, resisting the abstraction that enables generic argument templates and the drift toward what Goodnight (1982) identified as the technical sphere of argumentation.

Furthermore, the structure cultivates collaborative alongside combative skills. Value Defenders must persuade the Subject, a sympathetic listener making a genuine decision, not defeat an opponent. This corrects the misaligned procedural bleed by developing communication habits adapted to contexts beyond competitive debate, where genuine persuasion requires calibrating arguments to the specific beliefs and values of one’s audience (Cirlin, 1997/2002). The Subject also creates a natural accessibility incentive: if a Value Defender speaks incomprehensibly, their arguments are simply not weighed in the decision, a consequence that incentivises clarity.

Crucially, the format assigns each team a *value* rather than a *solution*. Values function as identity facets (Bowman, 2010): they are emotionally resonant, identity-constitutive, and generative of self-narrative in ways that instrumental solutions are not. A team that *believes in* a value is an interested party with a genuine stake, not a policy analyst assigned a position. Their role as solver-with-an-interest is only coherent if the solution they propose is genuinely derived from that value rather than given in advance. Prescribing the value while leaving the solution open forces each team into an act of authentic advocacy, and forecloses the drift toward generic argument templates that abstract motions invite.

5.3.2 Why Split Subject and Evaluator?

In traditional formats, a single judge both determines the winner and provides feedback, entangling evaluation with adjudication. Inside Out separates these functions: the Subject makes decisions within the debate, while the Evaluator observes and offers commendations.

This split means winning the debate is not a goal in itself but a method for growing, symbolised through commendations rather than victories. Decision-making within the debate becomes an act not of arbitrating but of synthesizing toward a position by acknowledging the interplay between values, a form of procedural rhetoric that models how real-world deliberation works, steering corrupted memetic bleed away from value convergence and toward epistemic humility. The Subject learns to synthesize; the Value Defenders learn to persuade collaboratively; and the Evaluator, freed from adjudicating competition, can focus on recognizing communicative virtue, maintaining the transformational container by decoupling status from competitive victory.

The format’s final speech (S2) extends this logic to the round’s conclusion. The Subject’s closing synthesis requires them to name a concrete decision and explain what arguments and values actually moved them. The round ends not with one side claiming victory over the other but with an acknowledgment of how competing values were weighed and reconciled. This procedural rhetoric of synthesis over combat reinforces the format’s core departure from debate-as-adversarial-validation, and models the kind of deliberative closure that characterises genuine decision-making rather than competitive performance.

5.3.3 Why Commendations and Oral Feedback?

Replacing scores and victory with commendations moves the format from a paradigm of competing against others toward one of improving oneself. The format recognises that debaters can demonstrate excellence in fundamentally different ways, a principle made concrete by commendation categories spanning qualitatively distinct skills (“Believable Passion”, “Argument Ingenuity”, “Resilience”) and by a badge progression system that builds unique skill profiles over time. The theoretical framework predicts that design interventions for the compromised container should distribute status more broadly and emphasise growth over victory; the commendation system is the direct structural implementation of both predictions. When status derives from demonstrated growth rather than competitive outcome, the zero-sum dynamics that erode the transformational container (Bowman & Hugaas, 2021; Bowman et al., 2025) are structurally dismantled.

The commendation system also resolves a persistent tension in modern debate formats between content density and persuasive discourse, precisely the misaligned procedural bleed identified in the theoretical framework. Commendations dissolve this conflict: debaters can pursue recognition for persuasive discourse alongside and equally with recognition for academic rigor and complexity, because these are separate categories rather than competing dimensions collapsed onto a single scale.

This growth orientation extends to the post-round debrief. In traditional formats, the oral critique centres on the adjudicator’s decision: who won, why, and what would have changed the result. The evaluative frame orients debaters entirely toward competitive performance. Inside Out reframes this as oral feedback centred on demonstrated skills and developmental

trajectory: the Evaluator explains the commendations awarded, articulates why particular moments demonstrated particular skills, and offers advice oriented toward growth rather than toward winning a future round. This connects the debate experience to the debater’s broader developmental arc, maintaining the transformational container by structuring the debrief around growth rather than victory — precisely the debrief function Crookall (2014) and Daniau (2016) identify as essential to lasting transformation.

5.4 Design Additions from Playtesting

Two structural additions made following the first playtest merit full theoretical justification. Both emerged from participant feedback and observational data (reported in Annex F), and both introduce genuinely new procedural rhetoric. Other changes from that iteration (Points of Information, silent thinking time, motion enrichment, ritual simplification) are refinements or clarifications of mechanisms already justified above.

5.4.1 Why the Opening Subject Speech?

An opening Subject speech (S0, here referred to as S1 in the final speech order) was added in which the Subject holds a monologue as the character, expressing why this decision is truly difficult and why each value is relevant.

The opening speech does not operate in isolation but in concert with the Rolling In and Rolling Out rituals that bracket every round. Rolling In — each participant declaring their role aloud before the debate begins — functions as the transformational container’s liminal entry threshold (Bowman et al., 2025): participants are explicitly transitioned from everyday identity into role. The Opening Speech, placed immediately after, completes what the ritual initiates: the Subject’s voice performing genuine uncertainty as a specific character makes that character vivid to all participants at the moment the container has just been opened. The corresponding Rolling Out — de-rolling, handshakes, and bleed check — closes the container arc. Taken together, Rolling In, the Opening Speech, and Rolling Out constitute the round’s full container structure rather than mere procedural bookends.

By requiring the Subject to speak first as their character, the format also ensures that all subsequent debate proceeds from a particular person’s situation rather than a universal proposition. The theoretical framework predicts that a design intervention against misaligned procedural bleed should involve constructing vivid characters for the Evaluator to hold in mind, so that bleed-in from the character’s situation becomes memetic rather than filtered through the Evaluator’s own background and values. The Opening Speech is the structural mechanism that enacts this prediction: by hearing the Subject speak as the character before any argument is made, the Evaluator’s evaluative frame is anchored to a specific person’s dilemma rather than to the Evaluator’s own pre-existing assessments. The same vividness operates for Defenders, who calibrate their arguments to a person they have heard rather than an abstraction. Together these effects make the motion irreducibly personal, resisting the drift Goodnight (1982) identified from personal and social spheres toward the technical — the abstraction of singular decisions into universal prescriptions. This also replaces the first design’s interstitial S1 (in which the Subject committed to a preliminary

decision after the first Defender round) with a more theoretically motivated intervention: grounding specificity at the outset rather than mid-debate.

5.4.2 Why the Huddle?

The Huddle is a structured interval after the first round of Defender speeches in which the Subject team may question any Defender, grant and revoke the floor, and prompt direct clashes, replacing the interstitial S1 entirely.

Theoretically, the Huddle simulates a council of competing interests. The dynamic is simultaneously cooperative and conflictual: Defenders can form alliances, acknowledge each other’s arguments, and concede ground to gain the Subject’s trust, while still competing for influence over the final decision. This procedural structure embeds a dynamic absent from binary debate formats: the collaborative-conflictual texture of real deliberative bodies, where stakeholders negotiate among themselves while simultaneously advocating to a decision-maker. The procedural rhetoric of the Huddle teaches that resolution does not arise from one side defeating the other, but from interests being forced to confront, clarify, and — sometimes — reconcile.

The Huddle also generates a distinct pattern of procedural bleed (Hugaas, 2024) not produced by traditional debate. Traditional debate bleeds adversarial monologue habits: constructing extended causal chains under pressure, optimized for expert judges. The Huddle bleeds deliberative habits instead: directed questioning, identifying where two arguments have not yet engaged and creating the conditions for them to do so, adapting argument in real time to a specific interlocutor’s voiced needs. These are precisely the skills Cirlin (1997/2002) associated with genuine persuasion through audience adaptation — but the Huddle makes audience adaptation the primary structural mechanic of the interval rather than a secondary consideration. Such habits transfer to facilitated meetings, mediation, and collaborative decision-making: real-world contexts that traditional debate’s adversarial procedural bleed works against rather than toward.

5.5 Synthesis and Design Tensions

Several tensions in this design constitute productive questions for playtesting. Will competitive motivation survive without win-loss outcomes, or will debaters socialized in traditional formats experience commendations as insufficient stakes? The Subject team bears a unique cognitive burden in synthesizing three value streams, and whether this is productive challenge or overwhelming difficulty depends on experience level and motion complexity. The format’s novelty (four teams, new roles, unfamiliar mechanics) may create barriers to entry for newcomers. Without victory as evaluative anchor, commendation judgments may feel more subjective; clear criteria and Evaluator training will likely be essential.

6 RESULTS

The question admits two decomposed sub-questions. First: can a research method of applying transformative game design theory to this problem domain be demonstrated? Second:

does that research method yield expected results? Each is addressed in turn.

6.1 Demonstrating the Method: The Design Process as Contribution

The first sub-question is answered by the thesis itself. The systematic progression from theoretical analysis through iterative design to empirical testing constitutes a worked example of operationalizing transformative game design theory in debate. The reasoning connecting each design iteration to observed player behavior is documented in Annexes A, B, and G; whether or not the resulting format succeeds transformatively, the method has been rendered explicit and repeatable.

6.2 Evaluating the Results: Evidence from Playtests

The second sub-question concerns whether the designed format shows signs of achieving its intended effects. Two playtests were conducted and analyzed using the clue-taxonomy method described in Section 4; the complete taxonomy is in Annex I. Each of the five evaluation fields corresponds to a prediction made in Section 5 on the basis of the theoretical framework, and each is assessed below as a constellation of clues whose configuration, rather than any single observation, points toward an answer.

Each field opens with a verdict drawn from a controlled vocabulary—*strongly confirmed*, *confirmed*, *confirmed in outcome with informative deviation in mechanism*, *confirmed at proof-of-concept level*, or *not confirmed*—which the body then justifies.

Clue weighting follows Section 4: behavioral evidence above self-report; unsolicited above prompted; cross-session above single-session; novel behaviors above continuities with standard formats. The meaningful absence of predicted negative clues counts as supporting evidence, particularly where it holds under conditions that would otherwise generate them. No single clue is treated as decisive; the case for each prediction rests on whether the configuration of positive clues, negative clues, and meaningful absences converges.

6.2.1 Field 1: Engagement, Appeal, and Long-Term Viability

Field 1 asks whether the format generates genuine voluntary engagement of the kind any transformative aim requires: without it, the transformational container cannot form, and the repeated participation that enables bleed and skill development cannot occur. The Inner Voices framing and removal of win/loss outcomes were predicted to generate this engagement by replacing status-competition with imaginative investment, with onboarding cost predicted as real but not prohibitive. The prediction was *confirmed*: imaginative investment manifested in emergent behavior the ruleset did not script, and the differential engagement pattern across participant profiles is consistent with design intent.

The constellation has a primary behavioral cluster, two converging supports, and a differential pattern that is confirmation, not ambiguity. The primary signal is spontaneous adoption of “inner voices” as in-play address, a term absent from the ruleset and generated organically during play—behavioral, novel, unsolicited, indicating imaginative investment

that exceeded the format’s explicit scaffolding. Two converging supports tighten the picture: animated post-session conversations extending beyond the structured debrief in both sessions, and players experimenting with uninstructed and unrewarded creative choices (accents, performance styles, personal props), each registering engagement that ran ahead of the format’s explicit incentive structure. Self-reports add a third strand—the format “surprisingly liberating,” the Huddle phase “very very fun”—unsolicited and convergent across two independent groups, weighed below the behavioral evidence by the weighting hierarchy but coherent with it.

The differential engagement pattern is itself evidence that emancipatory bleed (Kemper, 2017, 2020) is operating as theorized. In the sessions observed, women and debaters with less successful traditional-format track records expressed consistent preference, while three of the fifteen participants across both sessions—all competitive men with strong traditional-format track records—expressed reservations, one describing the format as “anticlimactic” and missing the “ego-boosting” experience of decisive victory. The format was not designed to serve the highly competitive profile that traditional formats already serve; its appeal to the voices the established container suppresses is what the framework predicts when status-competition is replaced by imaginative investment under a strengthened alibi (Bowman & Hugaas, 2021; Deterding, 2017).

Two qualifications follow, neither against the core prediction. The commendation system produced a subtler negative clue: Evaluators in both sessions found commendation assignment cognitively overwhelming at small informal scale. The system was designed for tournament use where Evaluators have prior familiarity with the badge list; the difficulty observed here is a calibration issue specific to off-tournament context, not a structural failure. The 40-minute onboarding brief confirms a real learning curve, while both sessions producing substantively engaged play within a single session aligns with the prediction that cost is one of onboarding rather than fundamental inaccessibility. The Rolling Out ritual recurred as a disengagement signal across both sessions; its primary discussion is in Field 3, where its bleed-arc implications are most acute.

Engagement is necessary but insufficient: whether the removal of win/loss outcomes also removed the productive intellectual challenge that drives growth is what Field 2 addresses.

6.2.2 Field 2: Productive Pressure Mechanisms

Field 2 asks whether productive intellectual pressure persists after removal of win/loss outcomes. The prediction, addressing what Section 5 identified as the format’s central design tension, was that pressure would be redirected rather than removed, with the commendation architecture replacing victory as the evaluative anchor. The prediction was *confirmed in outcome with an informative deviation in mechanism*: pressure persisted at high levels across both sessions, but the operative driver was an emergent social-recognition dynamic rather than the formal commendation system the design predicted.

The constellation answers two layered questions. The outcome (was pressure preserved?) is confirmed by a convergence of behavioral evidence, self-report, and meaningful absence; the mechanism (what drove the pressure?) is read off the deviation between predicted and observed driver. On the outcome side, the first session produced elaborate, nuanced solutions with careful value-priority arguments and passionate speeches, and the second pro-

duced contextually rich, roleplay-oriented speeches with uninstructed worldbuilding detail. The risk that emotional expressiveness might displace analytical rigor did not materialize: practical reasoning and value hierarchies remained present alongside the emotional engagement. A first-session self-report (“architecting solutions” as “very complex and interesting strategically”) aligns with the behavioral picture. A novel positive clue from the second session adds force: participants spontaneously initiated a group conversation about how to diminish another Inner Voice’s contribution without being dismissive, a growth discussion standard debate does not produce because the skill is not rewarded there. The absence of apathy in both sessions, with no participant reducing effort in the win/loss vacuum, weighs as supporting evidence by the weighting hierarchy.

On the mechanism side, the operative driver was not the commendation architecture but a social one: participants wanted recognition from fellow Inner Voices and from the Subject for the quality and resonance of their contributions. The commendation system provided the evaluative frame, but peer recognition motivated effort. This is an informative deviation rather than a failure: it refines the procedural-rhetoric account (Bogost, 2007) by showing that the operative rule can be a social rule emergent from the formal structure rather than the formal scoring rule itself, and it converges with the Field 4 finding that informal social reward did the work of formal commendation when the latter was unreliable.

The qualification is the Subject role’s scaffolding gap, this field being the primary locus for the issue. In the first playtest, the Subject described not knowing “what to say,” uncertain how to hold emotional investment and evaluative neutrality at once; this was addressed in the second iteration’s instructions. A second scaffolding issue then emerged in the second session, where the Subject ran out of prepared Huddle questions before the allotted time. That session also offered a partial resolution: the Subject who navigated the role most successfully was the one who leaned into roleplay rather than maintaining analytical detachment. Inhabiting the character, responding emotionally, and asking from genuine curiosity resolved the cognitive tension between roleplay and evaluation, consistent with the broader argument in Section 2 that debate is fundamentally a form of role-playing.

With pressure preserved and the mechanism refined toward emergent social dynamics, Field 3 asks whether the same redirection produces useful growth—whether the pressure is channeled toward skills and perspectives that transfer beyond the debate context.

6.2.3 Field 3: Growth Direction – Useful Skills and Perspectives

Field 3 asks whether the format’s procedural rhetoric—the rule structure of Inner Voices roles, S0 bias disclosure, and Subject framing—elicits perspective-taking, contextual reasoning, and collaborative discourse without explicit instruction, because the rules themselves structurally reward these behaviors. The prediction, derived from Bogost (2007), was that no participant should need to be told to take other perspectives; the format would make any other approach unnatural. The prediction was *strongly confirmed*: three independent behavioral clusters from the second session each registers a different facet of the predicted shift, converging on a single finding and supported by first-session self-reports and a cross-session arc of divergence from standard-debate conventions.

The constellation comprises three behavioral clusters, each registering a different facet of the prediction. First, players immediately adopted second-person address, direct eye con-

tact with the Subject, and contextual worldbuilding from the opening of the debate, all uninstructed—a behavioral and unsolicited indicator that perspective-taking was the dominant orientation. Second, players developed a collaborative form of counter-argumentation: rather than dismantling opposing arguments, they shifted focus and built on others’ contributions, exhibiting in their speeches the very norm against adversarial rebuttal they articulated explicitly during debrief (see Field 4). Third, across the second round of speeches players moved spontaneously toward alignment on a common solution—a behavioral inversion of standard debate’s production pattern, transcript-confirmed and novel, the clearest instance of procedural rhetoric functioning as designed. The three clusters converge on one mechanism: where standard formats reward dismantling argument, Inside Out scores contextual contribution and rewards no rebuttal, so the rhetorical strategy that earns the most evaluative reward is the one Bogost (2007) predicts the rule structure should produce.

Two further strands tighten the picture. First-session self-reports articulated the conceptual shift retrospectively—learning “to think about the context of decisions,” to be “more human and more honest about human nature,” to recognize that “sometimes decisions are personal, not universal”—moderate evidence in isolation but consistent with the behavioral cluster of the second session. Moreover, an arc visible across both sessions shows play diverging from standard-debate conventions speech by speech as each session progressed, the novel-over-continuity rule weighting these adjustments as effects of the format rather than imported habits. The two predicted negative clues, unhelpful play rewarded and hollow performative emotionality, did not manifest in either session.

The qualification concerns architecture, not evidence. The Rolling Out ritual is the most significant growth-direction design gap: emancipatory bleed (Kemper, 2017, 2020) requires a sustained transformational container (Bowman et al., 2025) through the closing moment, and a closing ritual that breaks immersion directly undermines the bleed arc on which growth depends. The point bears emphasis: the in-round behaviors confirm the procedural-rhetoric account fully; the gap concerns whether the container holds long enough for emancipatory bleed to land after the round closes. The redesigned version in the third iteration (Annex H) addresses this directly but remains untested in this thesis cycle.

With growth direction confirmed at the level of in-round behavior, Field 4 asks whether the same structural logic that orients players toward perspective-taking also reshapes the surrounding social space—whether the format becomes a community people will return to.

6.2.4 Field 4: Community Dynamics and Reduced Toxicity

Field 4 asks whether removing win/loss outcomes and reshaping the evaluative structure toward commendation reduces the adversarial dynamics that drive community attrition and harm. The prediction was that status derived from demonstrated growth, rather than from competitive victory, would dismantle the dynamics that erode the transformational container. The prediction was *strongly confirmed*: the constellation of behavioral norms, multi-source self-reports, and meaningful absences across two independent sessions shows the strongest cross-clue convergence in the dataset.

The constellation converges from four directions. The clearest behavioral signal is an emergent norm against adversarial rebuttal: in the second playtest, participants spontaneously articulated that “outright attacking others’ points feels wrong, disrespectful, and

unnecessary”—a norm absent from the ruleset, arising from the format’s structural logic. This is procedural rhetoric in the precise sense Bogost (2007) theorizes: rebuttal carries no competitive benefit while contextual contribution does, inverting the rhetorical incentive structure of standard debate. Reduced anxiety converges from another angle: across both sessions, participants independently reported the format as “much much less anxiety-inducing,” described a “feeling of salvation regardless of result,” and noted that “everyone distinguished himself by his own style”—unsolicited, multi-source reports across two independent groups, the most multiply confirmed positive clue in the dataset and consistent with the transformational container forming as theorized (Bowman & Hugaas, 2021; Bowman et al., 2025).

Brave, unconventional play forms a third strand: vulnerable, emotionally intimate approaches in the first session and roleplay-heavy delivery, soundtrack-opened Subject speeches, and worldbuilt characters with emotional stakes in the second drew immediate gestural reward (laughing, nodding, leaning forward). This experimentation was possible because the Inner Voices framing operates as Deterding’s (Deterding, 2017) alibi, distancing performer from position and removing the identity threat that constrains risk-taking in win/loss formats. The fourth direction is what was *not* observed: none of the three predicted negative clues (distress, arrogant or unempathetic behavior, praise of such behavior) manifested across either session, despite participants being experienced competitive debaters with established adversarial habits and despite the second session’s moments of genuine emotional intensity (see Field 5).

Two qualifications narrow the result without weakening it. The anxiety reduction may carry a novelty-artifact component: with no established status, less social capital is staked on performance, and a portion of the reduction may reflect that initial condition rather than a structural feature that would persist in a mature Inside Out circuit. The qualification is one of durability under maturation, not of the structural effect demonstrated within the playtest window. The commendation system’s calibration immaturity at small scale, noted in Field 1, recurs here in a more theoretically revealing form: where the formal commendation channel was unreliable, the room’s gestural and verbal social reward did the same evaluative work—a second instance of the social-recognition mechanism named in Field 2.

Field 4 establishes that the format’s structural logic reshapes the social space surrounding play; Field 5 tests whether the same logic produces the deepest predicted transformation: a measurable shift in how participants hold their own beliefs.

6.2.5 Field 5: Epistemic Humility

Field 5 tests the deepest predicted transformation: that the Inner Voices framing, the S0 bias disclosure, the absence of a winner, and the multi-perspective structure produce a shift in how participants hold their own beliefs not as a taught skill but as an emergent consequence of inhabiting the format’s structural logic. The mechanism is memetic bleed (Hugaas, 2024; Leonard & Thurman, 2018) steering toward value pluralism rather than convergence. The prediction was *confirmed at proof-of-concept level*: the constellation centers on the single highest-strength clue in the dataset and is supported by behavioral, articulated, and absent-as-evidence strands.

The constellation has a focal observation and three in-play correlates that show the same

mechanism in its in-round form. The focal observation is an unplanned bleed event in the second session: a participant disclosed privately to the researcher that the scenario in play resonated with a real-life situation they were facing that same day. This is the highest-strength clue in the dataset because three weighting principles align: it is behavioral rather than self-report, it is private rather than performed for the researcher, and it instantiates the transformational mechanism directly, with the format’s content crossing the play/life boundary as a memetic resource for an actual decision (Hugaas, 2024). One event in one session is not generalizable, but as proof-of-concept evidence it shows the mechanism functioning exactly as theorized.

Three in-play correlates fill out the picture. Synthesis orientation emerged across both rounds of Inner Voices speeches, appearing in the first round and intensifying in the second—spontaneous drift toward convergence despite no rule incentivizing it, transcript-confirmed and novel, the clearest behavioral indicator that the format’s structural logic orients participants toward integration rather than dominance. Players in the second session organically renamed themselves “Inner Voices” during play, positioning themselves as parts of a shared internal deliberation rather than as opposing sides (subsequently formalized in the third iteration). The second-session debrief produced a meta-confirmation: participants independently identified that the S0 institutionalizes surfacing personal biases openly before argumentation, reframing bias as perspective rather than contamination—an analysis they arrived at without prompting, which is itself evidence the mechanism functioned: the format made its own epistemic logic visible to its players. First-session self-reports converge from another angle: one participant articulated the attitudinal shift unprompted (“every team says valuable stuff and it is important more to see what is important to us”), and others observed that arguing someone is “morally wrong” for a personal decision feels “a bit absurd” in this format. The strands together trace one phenomenon: value pluralism replacing value convergence as the format’s procedural lesson (Bogost, 2007).

Three qualifications limit what can be claimed. The bleed event is a single observation; one occurrence under one set of conditions cannot demonstrate persistence. Both sessions used small samples of experienced debaters; whether the same configuration produces the same effect at scale is what the next design cycle would test. No longitudinal follow-up was conducted; the durability of the shift beyond the playtest window is unestablished. By contrast, the absence of unequivocal condemnation of positions or belief-holders, or praise of such condemnation, holds across both sessions despite motions involving genuine ethical weight and participants practiced in adversarial argumentation, strengthening confidence beyond what the positive clues alone would justify.

Field 5 closes the field-level analysis. The cross-field synthesis follows: how the five fields together support the design account, and which findings refine it.

6.3 Proof of Concept Assessment

The five fields together compose a single causal account rather than five independent verdicts. Engagement (Field 1) is the entry condition: without genuine voluntary investment, no further transformation is possible, and emancipatory bleed reaches voices the status-competition format suppresses. Productive pressure (Field 2) shows that the cognitive and social demands of the activity persist after win/loss removal, redirected through an emer-

gent social-recognition mechanism. Growth direction (Field 3) shows that the redirected pressure is channeled toward perspective-taking, collaborative framing, and synthesis orientation through the format’s procedural rhetoric. Community dynamics (Field 4) shows that the same structural logic shapes the social space: anxiety reduction, brave play met with gestural reward, an emergent norm against adversarial rebuttal. Epistemic humility (Field 5) shows that the deepest predicted effect—memetic bleed crossing into a real decision context—was confirmed by the unplanned bleed event and supported by spontaneous synthesis behavior, the “Inner Voices” renaming, and the S0 meta-confirmation. The chain is sequential in dependency: each later field’s confirmation rests on the earlier field’s effect being present.

Two cross-cutting framework concepts unify the account. Procedural rhetoric (Bogost, 2007) appears in the body of Fields 3, 4, and 5: a rule structure that rewards contextual contribution but not rebuttal produces the in-round behaviors of perspective-taking, collaborative framing, and synthesis, and—at the level of community dynamics—the explicit norm against adversarial rebuttal. Bleed mechanisms map onto the remaining fields: emancipatory bleed (Kemper, 2017, 2020) for Field 1’s reach to suppressed voices, procedural bleed for Field 3’s transferable skills, memetic bleed (Hugaas, 2024) for Field 5’s value-pluralism shift. Different framework concepts predict different fields’ effects, and each prediction holds—a coherence that is itself a form of confirmation, since the same designed structure produces effects of distinct theoretical type, suggesting the design account is internally coherent rather than field-specific post-hoc rationalization.

The most interesting design finding is a refinement of that account itself. Field 2’s mechanism deviation (social recognition driving pressure rather than commendations) and Field 4’s converging observation (informal social reward doing the work of formal commendation when calibration was unreliable) together suggest that rule-structure shapes behavior, but the operative rules need not be the formal scoring rules: they can be social-recognition rules that emerge from the formal structure. Future iteration on the commendation architecture should accordingly attend to the peer-recognition dynamics it enables rather than treating the formal evaluative structure as the primary lever. No single piece of evidence is conclusive, but the configuration of evidence across all five fields delivers a coherent design account: the format produces effects predicted by transformative game design theory, and the deviations it produces refine that account.

6.4 Limitations

Several limitations bound what these results can claim. First, the original design envisioned approximately four iterative playtest sessions; two were completed within the thesis timeline. Both yielded substantive observational and debrief data sufficient for proof-of-concept assessment, but the reduced iteration count narrows the breadth of design refinement reflected here. Second, two recurring design gaps—Subject role scaffolding (Field 2) and the Rolling Out ritual’s immersion-breaking effect (Field 3)—were partially addressed across iterations but remain open questions; both should be prioritized in the next design cycle. Third, both playtest groups consisted of experienced debaters already familiar with competitive formats; the format’s performance with novice participants, for whom the contrast with standard debate would be less salient, remains untested. Beyond these design-cycle limitations, the

methodological constraints articulated in Section 4 continue to bound inference: small sample sizes, the absence of longitudinal follow-up, and the researcher’s dual role as designer and observer mean that the constellation across the five fields supports a coherent design account but cannot demonstrate persistence, superiority, or generalizability.

7 Discussion

The results chapter established, clue by clue, that Inside Out behaves the way a transformative debate format is supposed to behave. This discussion does something different: it reads the playtests back through the theoretical framework of Section 3 to ask where the theory explains what happened, where the results press on its edges, and where the encounter between the two points toward extensions the framework needs if it is to operate at the level of precision intentional design demands. Several of the most striking findings emerged not because the framework correctly predicted them but in spite of its silence on them; those silences are the productive output of this thesis.

The extensions that follow in hope of pulling much not at straws address seemingly separate surfaces (alibi, judges, players, agencies, peers, evaluators, governance) but they converge on a single claim. *In a transformative competitive format, the rulebook is the smallest of the surfaces that the aggregate utility of participant’s experience.* The real work of design sits in the apparatus that surrounds the rulebook.

7.1 Alibi, Justification, and the Filter on What Survives in a Format’s Meta

The playtests reveal a distinction the framework does not yet draw. The Rolling Out ritual (mechanically identical in intent to many framing devices used in transformative LARP) was reported as “very robotic” in the first playtest and drew mumbling in the second, while the term “Inner Voices” was adopted spontaneously by the same participants. Both moves were formally licensed by the same alibi. What distinguished them reveals that the two senses of alibi Deterding (2017) and Bowman et al. (2025) employ are intertwined in ways the framework does not make explicit. Deterding’s alibi is the adult’s justification for playing at all: some adults have internalised a worldview in which play for its own sake is legitimate; others require an instrumental rationale: developing public speaking, practising empathy, or building argument skill. Bowman’s alibi is complementary: it is what the game permits the player to do once they have decided to play. But the two axes are not independent. The justification the adult accepts as licence to play also filters what they feel entitled to perform within the session: chanting as a ritual may fall outside what feels permitted in a session justified by “learning argumentation,” yet feel natural in one justified by “embodying a character who is a wizard.” The Rolling Out ritual failed because it satisfied neither the instrumental justification (it looked decorative) nor a genuine roleplay frame (it was too mechanical to feel like real embodiment); “Inner Voices” fitted both; it named the roleplay without ceremonialising it. A designer who does not attend to what justification-alibi their format offers its adult participants will not know which performance-alibis those participants will cash in.

This has a direct implication for the framework. Bowman et al. (2025)’s list of designable surfaces treats the container’s framing and ritual structure as one such surface, but does not distinguish between the alibi to play and the alibi to act within the play; more importantly, it does not analyse how each shapes the other. A framing device appropriate to a LARP weekend can be procedurally correct in a debate format and still fail, because the format’s justification-alibi sets a prior over which performance-alibis participants will exercise.

7.2 Value Convergence Revisited: The Judge as the Average Unbiased Person

The playtests support but also sharpen the corrupted-memetic-bleed account of value convergence (Section 3). The underlying pathology is beyond judges being demographically similar; that they are all asked to roleplay the *same* archetype (“the average, unbiased person”) is identified as cause. The words “average” and “unbiased” are themselves ideologically loaded. Everyone converging on one role produces drift regardless of the judges’ individual backgrounds, because the role itself pulls interpretation toward a single imagined audience and sanctions deviation. Inside Out’s second-playtest debriefs captured this almost verbatim: participants contrasted the S0 speech, which frames bias as perspective rather than contamination, against “the pretense of objectivity” they located in standard formats, and argued that the standard framing itself propagates the notion that only one kind of “objective” person can judge well.

Four structural choices in Inside Out act on this mechanism simultaneously: the Interlocutor roleplays a specific named character rather than a composite neutral; there are three teams rather than two; persuasion targets values rather than policy; and the S0 speech grants the Subject worldbuilding license, providing an explicit alibi to interpret the same character differently across rounds. Switch-side debating already cultivates humility through its own procedural rhetoric (Bogost, 2007); the design task is to defend that humility against the homogenizing pressure that otherwise leaks back in. The framework extension this suggests is that the judge-role’s psychological specificity is a first-order design variable, not a community-support afterthought. That this solution emerged at all is perhaps the clearest demonstration of the thesis’s central claim: only by treating debate as a roleplaying game and applying transformative game design theory could one have cracked the game-design code of this problem. Standard debate reform discourse frames the judge as a neutral arbiter to be better calibrated; transformative game design theory frames the judge as a character whose roleplay is the mechanism, and names the redesignable parameters.

7.3 Steering: A Missing Construct for the Subject’s Dual Stance

The first playtest’s Subject described not knowing “what to say,” caught between emotional investment and evaluative neutrality; the second playtest’s Subject resolved the tension by leaning into the roleplay rather than maintaining analytical detachment. The framework, as written, has no construct that names what the second Subject did. Bleed describes what flows into the player; alibi describes the social license to let it in; neither captures the player’s capacity to inhabit the character while retaining an external stance to notice what the scene is doing.

The Nordic theory of steering (Montola et al., 2015; Pohjola, 2015) is precisely this missing construct. Steering describes the player’s ongoing negotiation between in-character inhabitation and out-of-character authorship. Importing steering into the framework reframes the Subject’s evaluative burden as a teachable, trackable skill, something a format should plan for explicitly in its facilitation and training architecture, not attribute to individual participant disposition. Steering becomes a capacity a well-designed game can commendate, build toward, measure, and progressively develop.

7.4 Procedural Rhetoric and Agency: Nguyen Extends Bogost

Several of the strongest results were procedural rhetoric effects in Bogost (2007)’s sense: the emergent norm against adversarial rebuttal, the collaborative drift toward synthesis in the second round of Inner Voice speeches, and the spontaneous roleplay stance all arose from the format’s structural logic rather than from instruction. Nguyen (2020)’s account of games as the art of agency restates this point at a different altitude, and its addition to the framework is productive. Games shape players not only by the worldviews their rules encode (Bogost) but by the agencies they make available (Nguyen): what kinds of action, what kinds of deliberation, what shape of success the format authorizes the player to pursue. Inside Out authorizes a different agency than traditional debate (collaborative persuasion oriented toward a Subject’s decision rather than zero-sum victory over an opponent), and the emergent norms are what that different authorization looks like in play.

The framework extension is modest but useful: procedural rhetoric describes the argument a format makes; agency-shaping describes the kind of player it cultivates. Transformation sits at the intersection, and both lenses are needed to design for it. The playtests add a further note of caution for Bogost’s lens specifically: the results suggest that the game fiction’s symbolic veneer matters less than the action verbs the format makes available and the consequences those verbs carry. What a participant is *authorised to do* and *what follows when they do it* shapes transformation more reliably than what the fiction calls that action.

7.5 Social Recognition as the Pressure Mechanism

The framework anticipated that removing win-loss outcomes would require a replacement source of competitive motivation, and the commendation architecture was designed to provide it. The playtests report something the framework did not predict: the mechanic driving high effort was neither the win/loss dynamic nor primarily the commendation system, but a social one: participants wanted to be recognized and appreciated by their fellow Inner Voices and by the Subject for the quality and resonance of their contributions. Pressure was present and productive. Its source was peer regard, not progression.

This is a genuine gap in the existing transformative game design literature, which has extensive theory about the container, alibi, and bleed, but little about what sustains motivational intensity in the container’s absence of external competition. Social recognition within a bounded group is itself a transformational pressure: it aligns with the format’s goals (collaborative persuasion is what gets recognized), it operates at the speed of the session (no need for circuit-scale memory), and it is durable under the removal of win-loss. The framework extension is to name this explicitly as a third category of pressure alongside

competitive stakes and progression architecture, and to treat it as a designable surface in its own right.

7.6 Progression Architecture: Territory the Framework Has Not Charted

The commendation system succeeded in decoupling status from competition and was received with genuine enthusiasm (“scratching the make-a-build itch”), but evaluators reported difficulty assigning commendations consistently, and one raised the risk of “farming”: stylized play optimized for commendation coverage rather than development. Both difficulties point to the same problem: the framework specifies what transformation *is* (bleed, identity work, memetic uptake) but not how a facilitator *sees* it occurring in real time, and not how a progression architecture can be designed so that optimizing for its rewards equals the development it is meant to measure.

Gamification and progressive game design theory have developed substantial thinking on exactly this problem (progression paths, reward loops, and the alignment of extrinsic incentives with the intrinsic capacities they are meant to cultivate), all valuable writings that one should read and theoretically integrate were word counts more lenient lords.

7.7 Governance, Not Rules, Carries the Meta

The second playtest debrief produced the most important empirical observation in this thesis, and it is about something the framework does not address at all. Participants reconstructed how the drift toward speedtalking in British Parliamentary, and its later contamination of World Schools after the judge pools merged, was a *governance* story rather than a rules story. As the founding university teachers disengaged from BP, rule interpretation fell to whoever held social power in the circuit, and they systematically privileged the skill hardest to master (logical density) because that was what sustained their standing. A new format dropped into that community inherits the same governance pathology regardless of its ruleset.

Community support, as Bowman et al. (2025) frames it, is too thin a category: what matters is the *governance layer*: how rules are interpreted, how evaluators are trained, how motions are authored, how commendations are constructed and displayed across a season, and whose voice sets the meta’s direction of drift. This layer is not designed in this thesis, and it is more consequential for the format’s long-run behavior than anything in the format specification. The framework extension is to recognise governance structure as a designable surface of its own, sitting above the format rather than alongside it. Community management theory, which has developed sustained accounts of how interpretive communities form, drift, and resist intervention, represents a theoretical depth the framework would benefit from integrating; cut not one’s underfeet opportunity branch in the pursuit of further research.

7.8 Modularity, and an Honest Note on the Process

The framework tends to treat transformative formats as integrated wholes whose components reinforce one another. Inside Out’s design is also that, but it is additionally decomposable into five components each of which could be transplanted into an existing format without the

others: the commendation system; splitting the judge into an in-debate Interlocutor whose performance is itself evaluated and an external Evaluator whose is not; three teams rather than two; a judge who roleplays a specific named character; and teams prescribed values but granted creative freedom over the solutions that express them. The framework extension is a modularity lens: treating transformative designs as candidate sets of transplantable mechanisms rather than monolithic experiences.

8 Conclusion

Alfred “Tuna” Snider was first to recognize debate as a game and to apply play logic to its analysis, doing this way before game design was a recognized discipline. Through his career as a teacher and scholar he championed the transformative power of playing this game with joy, passion and determination. Although many of his students, one of whom I was privileged to be, continued his work across related fields, none used game-design know-how to answer the question that most naturally flows from his argument that debate is a game: how can we make it a better game? This thesis takes one step into that question.

A “how can” research question unfolds in three stages, and it is worth being explicit about which of them this thesis answered. The first stage asks whether the task is approachable at all, whether the conceptual tools required even apply to the object of study. Sections 2 and 3 answer this: debate is a class of transformative role-playing games, and the apparatus of transformative game design can be brought to bear on it without conceptual distortion. The second stage asks whether a concrete attempt at the task can be carried through. Sections 4–5 answer this by documenting the design of the Inside Out format and the iterative process through which it arrived at its current shape. The third stage asks whether the attempt produced anything of value. The results and discussion chapters answer this in their respective registers: clue-by-clue proof that the format behaves as theorized, and theory-facing extensions opened up by the encounter between framework and playtest.

To my own body of knowledge this thesis contributes most in becoming an artifact of academic frustration. Although Inside Out does constitute a first and not strictly necessary step in a much longer process of reform, whose later stages involve refinement, community adoption, governance design, and the slow work of shifting a meta, the utility of the scholarly wrapper as part of which it was developed fails yet to shine bright enough to warrant the effort put in constructing it. This is because the deductive arc this thesis narrates is but a necessary pretence. The actual design emerged intuitively and was retrofitted to theory; that it held testifies to the scholarly application of the argumentative skills debate builds, not to the merits of this theory-born deductive design methodology. One cannot but wonder how far the design would have evolved if effort were to have been invested in testing and refining and not in overcoming the difficulty of finding only over-18 playtesters and in wordsmithing convoluted theoretical analysis.

What this thesis carries forward, then, is not a finished format nor great insights but three more real boons for whose utility one can argue: - my emotional momentum required to pursue the subsequent stages of reform that the design itself cannot deliver; - misguided yet instrumentalizable academic legitimization of this format and my scholarly self, a tool for creating alibi of play and funding opportunities; - a wanton dream of such research being

picked up by those rare colleagues that find themselves also at the identity intersection of debate heritage, game-design career and scholarly ambitions.

"Tuna" proved that one can fund a lifestyle of meaningful teaching which helps hundreds of young people all by writing academic papers on how debate is a game. One can hope this lightning strikes twice.

Annex A — Inside Out Debate Format: First Design Iteration

The **Inside Out** format is an experimental debate format, designed using best practices from tabletop RPG game design. It seeks to be a more *fun*, *performance-growth oriented*, and *real-life skill-building* alternative to traditional competitive debate formats. Rather than winning arguments, debaters explore values, make meaningful decisions, and earn recognition for the skills they demonstrate.

8.0.1 Team Structure

Debaters are organised in four teams of two debaters each and are assigned positions within the debate at random:

- **Team S (Subject):** Represents the Subject of the Motion — the person who must face a decision. Must weigh all values and choose.
- **Teams A, B, and C (Value Defenders):** Each argues that a particular Value held by the Subject should be prioritised in the decision, and consequently, what the Subject should decide.

8.0.2 The Motion

The Motion outlines:

- What is the decision that has to be made.
- What is the background of the Subject and other relevant practical factors that can be taken into account within the decision.
- What are the three Values of the Subject, each assigned to one Value Defender team.

It is important to note that the Motion does not prescribe to the Value Defenders a particular position on what decision the Subject has to make. They have to construct it themselves.

8.0.3 Speech Order

The four teams hold alternating speeches in the following order:

A1, B1, C1, S1, A2, B2, C2, S2

Within their speeches, the Value Defenders argue for the relevance of their value, construct a specific decision that best honours it, and engage with the arguments forwarded by the other Value Defenders.

Within their speeches, the Subject team must outline a strong reasoning that engages with and explains the interplay between all arguments of the Value Defenders, picking a particular decision. Within S1 they pick a preliminary decision and within S2 a final decision.

8.0.4 Evaluation

The debate is overseen by an Evaluator, who performs two tasks:

Commendations. The Evaluator awards Commendations to debaters. Commendations represent acknowledgements of useful skills, knowledges, or attitudes. A list of awardable commendations is constructed by the Chief Evaluators of the Debate Tournament, along with the total number of Commendations that Evaluators can offer within that Tournament. Example commendations include Believable Passion, Witty Solution, Argument Ingenuity, and Resilience (see Section 9 of this Annex for the full list).

Over time, debaters who gather a particular commendation at least three times earn a Badge. Gathering it additional times upgrades the badge, an unlimited number of times, but each upgrade requires gathering three more Commendations than last time.

Oral Feedback. The Evaluator delivers an Oral Feedback session, in which they explain to each team the commendations they received, the reasoning behind them, and give advice on how each debater can improve in the future based on their performance.

8.0.5 Example Motion

You are the parent of a 16-year-old teenager. Your family is middle class and lives in the suburbia of a metropolis. You have higher education. You live in a country in which Higher Education is free, but there are only a few universities that are deemed as good. The year is 2026. You evaluate that your kid is talented in music, is a good leader and has had very good STEM skills, but is also quite distracted, does not have many friends and has failed to learn a foreign language. Your kid expressed a moderate interest in studying Musicology at university after they finish high school, but is also considering not going to higher education. You have a good relationship with your child. They asked you to suggest what they should do. What do you recommend your kid they should do after they finish high school?

Three Beliefs that you hold, relevant for this decision, are:

- In life, financial stability and independence is essential for a happy life.
- It is important to be a well-rounded, cultured individual.
- The people that you surround yourself with end up defining who you are.

8.0.6 Comparison with Traditional Formats

The table below contrasts Inside Out with World Schools debate along six dimensions.

	World Schools	Inside Out
Teams	2 teams $\times$ 3 members	4 teams $\times$ 2 members
Sides	Proposition vs. Opposition	3 Value Defenders + 1 Subject
Motion style	“This House...” policy/value motions	Personal dilemma with background & values
Goal	Win the argument — defeat the other side	Explore values — help the Subject decide
Evaluation	Scored on Content, Style & Strategy (points)	Commendations for skills & attitudes (badges)
Outcome	Win / Loss + speaker rankings	No win/loss — growth-oriented feedback

Key shift: Inside Out moves from adversarial persuasion to collaborative deliberation. There is no winner — instead, debaters earn commendations that recognise individual skills, and the Subject synthesises all perspectives into a reasoned decision.

8.0.7 Player Instructions

Value Defenders.

- Formulate arguments for why your value is **important, useful, and relevant** to this dilemma.
- Propose a **specific decision** that best honours your value — argue why it is right and leads to good outcomes, especially through the lens of your value.
- Engage with other Defenders’ **values**: show yours is more important, more relevant to the dilemma, or safer to follow.
- Engage with other Defenders’ **decisions**: attack, support (claiming it maximises your value), or endorse with addendums — choose your positioning wisely.
- Your core mission: **define what honouring your value looks like** in practice, and persuade the Subject it is the right path.

The Subject.

- **Enter without an opinion.** You are completely torn — you are here to listen and be persuaded, not to argue.
- Listen as if you *are* the Subject: **let the speeches move you** as they would move this person.
- Also take a mental step back: **evaluate how persuasive each argument would be** for the Subject, and adjust your lean accordingly.

- Take notes on arguments and their interplay — record what the Defenders say, **not your own personal thoughts**.
- **Collaborate quietly** with your partner: you are both embodying the same person, not competing.
- In your speeches, share which decision you are leaning toward and **why**, weighing all arguments to the extent they were persuasive. You must pick a specific decision, not merely name a value.

The Evaluator.

- Analyse the debate and each player’s performance. Decide which **commendations** to award — aim for one per debater (the same commendation can go to more than one person).
- Approach the round as an **educator** helping each player grow, not as a judge declaring a winner.
- Open with a **narrative of the debate** from your outside perspective: what each team did and how it all unfolded.
- Engage directly with each team: ask what they **felt they did well** and what they found difficult. Share your view and add your own observations.
- Ask each team what they want to **do better next time**, and give concrete advice on how to get there.
- Close by **awarding commendations** to each player.

8.0.8 Rituals

Rolling In.

1. **Team commitment chant** — Each team member states their commitment aloud before the debate begins:

Subject: *“I am [character name]. I am open to being moved.”*

Each Defender: *“I believe in [value]. I will argue from that belief.”*

Rolling Out.

1. **Subject’s thanks** — The Subject team thanks each Defender individually: *“Thank you for speaking your truth.”*
2. **Defenders’ thanks** — Each Defender team thanks the Subject: *“Thank you for listening and carrying the decision.”*

3. **De-roling** — Everyone stands. Each person states their real name and shakes hands with every participant: *“I am [name]. Thank you for playing with me.”*
4. **Bleed check** — The Evaluator asks quietly: *“Did anything in that debate feel close to home for anyone?”* — a brief, optional moment to name any emotional residue before moving into feedback. No one is required to answer.

8.0.9 Full Commendation List

Commendations are organised across five categories. Each commendation has three award tiers: *Earned* (threshold quality), *Strong* (clear excellence), and *Exceptional* (reserved for outstanding, rare performances). Some commendations carry role restrictions (Defenders only, or Subject only) as noted.

Style (*6 commendations — delivery, presence, and rhetorical quality*)

Believable Passion. You were truly invested in your point, showing genuine, believable conviction and care for the value you defended. Distinct from Honest Connection (self-disclosure) and Broad Range (technical delivery control).

Earned Tone conveyed genuine care at key moments; voice quality shifted naturally, eye contact held at key claims, word choices felt spontaneous.

Strong Conviction was felt in the substance of the speech; the room or the Subject visibly reacted.

Exceptional The delivery made the dilemma feel real and worth deeply caring about. Reserve for speeches where the affective dimension was genuinely transformative.

Entertaining Discourse. The speech was genuinely enjoyable through wit, lightness, or a well-timed observation that made the room smile or lean in. Distinct from Poetic Appeal (literary craft).

Earned At least one moment was distinctly enjoyable: a clever comparison, a light touch, or a well-timed observation.

Strong Liveliness was woven into the argumentation consistently; humor or vividness served to make points land more effectively.

Exceptional Entertainment and argument were seamlessly fused throughout, reaching the level of a sharp public talk where wit and substance were inseparable.

Broad Range. Your delivery showed impressive stylistic range, varying tone, rhythm, tempo, and volume to serve the speech. Distinct from Believable Passion (authenticity of feeling); rewards technical delivery control.

Earned At least two noticeably different delivery registers were used; the speech did not feel flat.

Strong Variation was deliberate and purposeful: shifts in pace or tone coincided with structural moments in the argument.

Exceptional The full palette was deployed with mastery; the debater controlled the room's attention through delivery alone.

Honest Connection. Something genuine about yourself entered the speech — a real disclosure rather than a rhetorical move — that created contact between the debater and the room. Distinct from Believable Passion (conviction); rewards self-disclosure and personal presence.

Earned At least one moment of genuine self-disclosure (an admission, first-person reflection, or personal statement of feeling) that felt real rather than strategic.

Strong The personal register appeared at key structural moments; eye contact moved around the room, direct second-person address, or deliberate pause.

Exceptional The speech was uniquely theirs; you felt the debater was genuinely present in the room with you.

Poetic Appeal. Language was used with aesthetic care, where rhythm, imagery, or metaphor elevated the speech as a piece of writing, independent of its entertainment value. Distinct from Entertaining Discourse (enjoyment response); rewards literary and rhetorical craft.

Earned At least one passage was noticeably well-crafted: a sentence that would stand alone as good writing, or a rhythmic construction that made a point feel inevitable.

Strong Poetic quality sustained across multiple moments; rhetoric served the argument.

Exceptional The speech had genuine literary quality; specific lines are still in your head afterward. Language itself became part of the argument.

True Embodiment. You convincingly inhabited your role, arguing and deciding from inside it rather than about it from outside. For the Subject: thinking, feeling, and deciding as the character. For Defenders: arguing from genuine conviction in the value.

Earned The role's reality guided the speech throughout; stated leanings tracked the actual arguments made.

Strong The embodiment elevated the entire round; you could see the speaker being moved, reconsidering, weighing.

Exceptional Not applicable; omit Exceptional tier for this commendation.

Strategy (*7 commendations — positioning, framing, and tactical intelligence*)

Specific Topicality. Arguments were sharply specific to this dilemma, this Subject, and these values, with no generic claims. Distinct from Advantageous Framing (evaluative lens); rewards the content of the arguments themselves.

Earned Most substantive claims grounded in the specifics of the motion: the Subject's background, the values as stated, the actual decision at stake.

Strong Topicality was strategic; the debater drew on details others missed.

Exceptional Every substantive move calibrated to this specific situation; the arguments would fall apart if the Subject or dilemma were changed.

Advantageous Framing. You defined the terms of discussion in a way that benefited your position before others could. Distinct from Specific Topicality (argument content) and Helpful Guiding (neutral Subject navigation).

Earned Explicitly established a coherent evaluation framework relevant to their value's claim.

Strong The framing did real structural work; other debaters had to address it, and the Subject engaged with it directly.

Exceptional The framing was original and visibly influenced the course of the debate. Award rarely.

Witty Solution. You proposed a concrete, value-informed solution to the dilemma, specific enough that it could only have come from someone defending your value. Distinct from Advantageous Framing (criteria); rewards the solution itself.

Earned The proposed solution was specific and thought through, demonstrably flowing from the defended value.

Strong Notably smart: navigated a genuine tension between values, or revealed an angle others missed.

Exceptional Elegant and surprising, more persuasive than alternatives precisely because of how the value was applied.

Brave Pivot. You changed position or conceded a point honestly, and it made your case stronger.

Earned Explicitly acknowledged an opponent's point had merit, or adjusted position in response to what was said.

Strong The pivot was strategic: conceding less important ground to better defend more important ground.

Exceptional Changed their mind in real time under pressure, arguing why the pivot extends rather than contradicts the previous position. Award with corresponding rarity.

Efficient Alliance. (*Defenders only*) You recognized when another Defender’s arguments complemented yours and built on that alignment.

Earned Acknowledged at least one point of genuine agreement with another Defender that strengthens the case for a decision.

Strong Explicitly constructed an alliance: “both Team A and I agree that X, which shows the Subject that the weight of argument points toward Y.”

Careful Positioning. (*Defenders only*) Your stance toward other Defenders’ decisions was deliberate and chosen rather than reactive, with positive effect.

Earned Response to other Defenders’ decisions was evidently chosen rather than accidental; the stance was coherently maintained.

Strong Positioning was in service of a coherent strategy; you could reconstruct the reasoning behind every stance taken, forming a consistent picture.

Helpful Guiding. (*Subject only*) You helped the room navigate the structure of the debate clearly, accurately, and fairly. Distinct from Advantageous Framing; the Subject’s role is neutral navigation, not partisan framing.

Earned At least one moment of genuine meta-level navigation, e.g. “the key question before us is now X, because Y has been established and Z has been challenged.”

Strong The guiding was structurally important, identifying a genuine turning point or consolidating arguments fairly to all sides.

Content (*9 commendations — argumentation, analysis, and engagement with the debate*)

Word Economy. You communicated clearly and efficiently; every minute of speaking time counted. Rewards form of expression, not argument substance.

Earned The speech did not waste significant time; arguments were stated without excessive preamble, redundant restatement, or filler.

Strong Concision actively served clarity: complex ideas were expressed with precision; understood fully on first hearing.

Exceptional The debater said something hard to say in few words; specific lines had a density of meaning that rewarded attention.

Rebuttal Ingenuity. Your rebuttal identified a non-obvious flaw in an opponent’s argument: a hidden assumption, internal tension, or unconsidered consequence. Distinct from Argument Ingenuity (novel constructive arguments) and Comprehensive Breadth (coverage).

Earned Identified a non-obvious weakness rather than the first available attack.

Strong Engaged with the strongest version of the argument and demonstrated why it fails even there.

Exceptional Changed the argumentative landscape; the rebuttal was difficult or impossible to satisfactorily respond to.

Rebuttal Prioritization. You made deliberate, strategic choices about where to concentrate your rebuttal effort, and those choices were correct. Distinct from Comprehensive Breadth (coverage); rewards deliberate focus over breadth.

Earned Concentrated force on the most important clashes, explicitly or implicitly flagging the allocation.

Strong Prioritization revealed genuine strategic intelligence; the choice of what to ignore was as deliberate as what was attacked.

Rebuttal Accuracy. You represented opponents’ arguments faithfully before responding — no mischaracterization, no straw-manning. No Exceptional tier; accuracy is a threshold quality. Award only when faithful representation was genuinely non-trivial.

Earned Paraphrased opponents’ arguments correctly; engaged with the most charitable understanding.

Strong Engaged with specific moments in specific speeches; accuracy made the rebuttal more effective, not just fairer.

Robust Logic. Your arguments were well-constructed: valid, plausible, and without significant logical gaps. Distinct from Impressive Argumentative Depth; logic asks whether the reasoning chain holds structurally.

Earned Main arguments had clear claim-warrant-impact structure; a reasonable person could follow without supplying missing steps.

Strong Logic held up under challenge: no internal contradictions, no steps requiring the audience to take things on faith.

Exceptional Genuinely tight; would require a sophisticated objection to dislodge; obvious objections anticipated within the argument itself.

Impressive Argumentative Depth. You went beyond the surface, interrogating implications, mechanisms, or philosophical roots. Distinct from Robust Logic (structural soundness) and Argument Ingenuity (novelty).

Earned At least one argument went meaningfully beyond its initial claim, explaining why the value’s demand is well-founded or what it would look like for the Subject to live by it.

Strong Depth sustained throughout; consistently pushed past surface-level argumentation.

Exceptional After the speech, you found yourself reconsidering something you had assumed you understood, or the argument illuminated a dimension of the value no other speech had touched.

Comprehensive Breadth. You engaged with the full scope of the debate, including inconvenient arguments. Distinct from Rebuttal Ingenuity (sharpness) and Rebuttal Prioritization (deliberate focus); rewards attentiveness across the full debate.

Earned Addressed the most important arguments from all other Defenders, not only the weakest or most convenient.

Strong Demonstrated careful listening throughout; the speech reflected the actual state of the debate.

Exceptional Managed to synthetically yet explicitly cover every significant aspect of the debate.

Argument Ingenuity. You produced an argument that was unexpected, non-obvious, and substantively illuminating. Distinct from Rebuttal Ingenuity (reactive) and Impressive Argumentative Depth (thorough development); rewards novelty and surprise.

Earned At least one argument was notably fresh: not typically heard in this kind of debate, logically coherent, and able to withstand an obvious first objection.

Strong Ingenious in the full sense: first surprised you, then convinced you, revealing something about the value or dilemma that prior thinking had missed.

Exceptional The argument changed the debate; others had to respond to it and it became a fixed reference point. Very rare, award accordingly.

Accurate Synthesis. (*Subject only*) You gave a fair, accurate, and well-organized account of the full state of the debate. Distinct from Comprehensive Breadth (Defenders’ engagement); rewards the Subject for faithfully describing and weighing what happened.

Earned Correctly identified the main arguments from each Defender and did not misrepresent or omit them, even where unfavorable.

Strong Showed genuine comprehension of the debate’s structure: an account of how arguments interacted, where they clashed, and what the real decision points were.

Exceptional Identified the strongest and weakest versions of each Defender’s case and grounded the final decision in a genuinely comprehensive account of the round.

Fairplay (*3 commendations — observe team dynamics & debrief, not only speeches*)

Teammate Support. You actively helped your partner formulate something difficult in a way that visibly contributed to the team’s performance. Look for: visible collaboration during prep time; a second speaker building clearly on something the first struggled with. Award when the help was substantive and its impact visible. Ask in the debrief if not fully observable.

Teammate Solidarity. You showed genuine support for your partner during a hard moment, without distancing yourself. Look for: body language and verbal behavior toward a partner after a difficult moment; a second speaker who picked up where a struggling first left off without implicitly throwing them under the bus. The difficult moment must have been real and the solidarity genuine. If ambiguous, ask in the debrief.

Strategic Problem-Solving. You demonstrated intelligent, adaptive problem-solving in the face of strategic challenges in the round. Look for: a visible strategy adjustment that worked; a debater who recognized a weakness in their own case and addressed it explicitly; coordinated strategic adaptation across both speeches. Both identifying and solving the problem must be visible and shared between the two team members.

Growth Mentality (*4 commendations — use the debrief; always name the specific moment in feedback*)

Applied Feedback. You visibly tried to apply feedback from a previous round; imperfect application still earns this. Evidence may come from direct comparison with a prior round or from the debater’s own account in the debrief. What matters is the genuine attempt rather than the outcome.

Out of Comfort Zone. You attempted something genuinely difficult for you and made a real go of it. Rewards the attempt, not the result. Comfort zone is individual; use the debrief to identify what was genuinely challenging. Ask directly if needed.

Tracking. You showed clear awareness of your own growth across debates: where you started, what you have worked on, and where you are heading. Distinct from Applied Feedback (applying specific feedback in one round); rewards the broader self-awareness of one’s development arc over time. Evidence may come from the debrief: the debater can articulate what they have improved, name skills still being worked on, and describe their trajectory with accuracy.

Resilience. You encountered a genuinely difficult moment and came out intact, or stronger. The difficult moment must have been real. Award for: a strong attack responded to with a composed second speech; a delivery stumble overcome mid-speech; an unexpected move handled with adaptability. Name the specific moment in feedback; this commendation must be concrete to be useful.

Annex B — Inside Out Debate Format: Second Design Iteration

The second design iteration is based on observations and participant feedback gathered during the first playtest (Jean Monet debate club, Bucharest, March 2026). See Annex F for a detailed first playtest report. The changes below supersede the corresponding elements in the first iteration (Annex A).

8.0.10 Speech Order Changes

The interstitial S1 speech between the first and second rounds is removed. In its place, two new elements are introduced:

S0 — Subject Opening Speech. A new opening speech before any Defender speaks. The Subject team introduces the dilemma and argues why it is genuinely hard: all three values are relevant, the decision is real, and there is no obvious right answer. This speech gives the debate proper gravitas before Defenders begin.

The Huddle. A 10-minute interval inserted after C1 (and before A2). The Subject team may ask direct questions to any Defender team, grant them the floor to answer, and revoke their right to speak at any point. The Huddle allows the Subject to control the conversation toward resolving argumentative tensions, forcing arguments that need to interact to interact.

Thinking Time. A 2-minute silent thinking period is added before S2, giving the Subject team time to integrate all arguments before delivering their final decision.

The new speech order is:

S0, A1, B1, C1, [The Huddle], A2, B2, C2, [2-min thinking time], S2

Points of Information (POIs) are introduced during all speeches: any debater may signal to the current speaker to ask a brief question.

8.0.11 Motion Changes

- The Subject character description in the motion should include a longer list of the Subject’s personal beliefs and past decisions, to flesh out the character more fully and enable value-specific argumentation.
- Value Defenders should address the Subject in the second person (“you, as the Subject, should...”) rather than in the third person, reinforcing the personal and direct character of the deliberation.

8.0.12 Evaluation Changes

Commendations are awarded in private: after the debate, the Evaluator approaches each team separately rather than delivering commendations in a public session. The oral feedback narrative and growth-oriented debrief remain public.

8.0.13 Speech Instruction Clarifications

- Subject instructions explicitly state that the Subject must pick a specific *decision* (a concrete course of action), not merely name a value they find most important.
- More explicit guidance is provided on what the Subject team should prepare during prep time: for S0, they should prepare to explain the dilemma's genuine difficulty and why all values are relevant; for S2, they should prepare to synthesise all arguments and justify a final specific decision.

Annex C — Debrief Form

The following questionnaire was administered to participants after the first playtest. Questions aim to gather data on entertainment value, format distinctiveness, participant intentions, and transformative effects.

1. How fun was the debate? (scale 1–10)
2. How fun was it compared to a debate in a traditional format? (5-choice scale)
3. Was there anything surprisingly entertaining or engaging about it?
4. Was there anything about the format that was quite difficult, to the point of frustration?
5. Was there anything about the rules of the format that was confusing?
6. Would you play this format some more? (Yes / No)
7. If you would play it some more, in what circumstance would you?
8. If there was to exist an alternative debate circuit centred around this format, would you attend those competitions? Even at the expense of competitions in the WS or BP format?
9. Do you believe you played differently than you would have in a debate in WS/BP with a rather similar motion? If so, how?
10. Do you feel different than how you usually feel after a debate? If so, how?
11. Did you perceive yourself and others speaking similarly or differently than how you do in a regular debate? If so, how?
12. Were you to redo this debate, what would you do differently?
13. Were you to play more in this format, but on different motions, what would you do differently?
14. What do you believe you learned from this debate?
15. What do you believe this debate format does better, as a learning/empowerment tool, than WS or BP? Do you believe it does something worse?

Annex D — Playtest Motion

The following motion was used in the first playtest at the Jean Monet debate club, Bucharest, March 2026.

First version. Used in the first playtest at the Jean Monet debate club, Bucharest, March 2026.

You are Alex. You are a lawyer. You are close to your older brother Matei. He is a very caring person to everyone, always eager to help even strangers. He always helped you when you were in need. However he was always quite dishonest with you, and you caught him lying even about important things. Matei is also an alcoholic and you believe he is quite bigoted.

Matei was involved in a hit and run recently. He hit a cyclist that ended up hospitalised. The cyclist remembered his license plate only partially and he is now being investigated by the police. From your knowledge they only have circumstantial evidence, but he still risks going to jail. He asked you to lie that he was with you at home at the time of the accident, in order to provide him an alibi. Your assessment as a lawyer is that this will almost certainly exonerate him. However, a very small risk remains that additional material evidence could be found, at which point you might become an accessory to the crime.

What should you do?

Three Values that you hold, relevant for this decision, are:

- You believe that helping people in need is very important, and a moral duty.
- You believe in justice: that people should receive what they deserve.
- You believe that family should stick together and have each other's back.

Second version. Used in the second playtest, April 2026.

Alex is a criminal defence lawyer with seven years of experience. The eldest of three siblings from a small town, Alex was the first in the family to attend law school. After graduating, Alex spent two years at a legal aid clinic representing clients who could not afford private counsel, before joining a private firm. Alex's first major case there was defending a driver charged with causing serious injury in a road accident — Alex secured his acquittal.

Matei is Alex's older brother and the two have remained close throughout their lives. Matei is known among everyone who knows him for being eager to help others, often going out of his way even for strangers. He helped Alex through several difficult periods. He has also been dishonest with Alex repeatedly over the years, including about important matters. Matei struggles with alcohol and holds a number of views that Alex finds bigoted.

Matei was recently involved in a hit-and-run: he struck a cyclist who was hospitalised. The cyclist recalled his license plate only partially, and Matei is now under police investigation. As far as Alex knows, the evidence against him is circumstantial. Matei has asked Alex to lie and say he was at home with Alex at the time of the accident. Alex's legal assessment is that this would almost certainly exonerate him, though a small risk remains that additional material evidence could surface — at which point Alex would become an accessory to the crime. **What should you do?**

Values:

1. You believe that helping people in need is very important, and a moral duty.
2. You believe in justice, that people should receive what they deserve.
3. You believe that family should stick together and have each other's back.

Annex E — Informed Consent Form

I, _____ of _____ years of age, voluntarily accept to participate in a playtest followed by an interview session, both moderated by Andrei Dan Olaru, as part of his “*Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate*” study. This study seeks to explore the creation of an alternative debate format, informed by modern transformative game design theory. I understand that:

1. This session implies video recording of the entire debate playtest and the subsequent collective interview, plus some additional questions using an online questionnaire.
2. Pseudonyms will be used when analysing the data for confidentiality, and the researchers commit to not revealing the identities of the participants. Individual raw data may be discussed in class or with the supervisor without the participant’s name to trace back to. The data obtained will be analysed by grouping and some textual examples will be used anonymously.
3. The recording will be safely stored in the university’s OneDrive to maintain the saved raw interviews protected. The video will be erased one month after the dissertation’s results. The transcripts will be erased up to one year after the dissertation’s results.
4. None of the questions will go against my integrity, no harm will come to me during this session, no answer is right or wrong and I may choose not to answer any question(s) without consequences of any kind.
5. I am free to walk out of the playtest and interview at any time if I deem it necessary without prejudice or any consequences.

For any additional information or difficulty, the participant may contact the researcher Andrei Dan Olaru at `andrei-dan.olaru.0744@student.uu.se`.

Participant’s signature

Researcher’s signature

I, _____ have been informed of the conditions and freely accept to participate in the research by Andrei Dan Olaru.

Participant’s signature

_____ of March
2026
Date

Annex F — First Playtest Report

The following is a first-person account of the first playtest session, held in March 2026 at the Jean Monet debate club in Bucharest. The session gathered six senior debaters (aged 18–20). Design changes arising from this playtest are documented separately in Annex B.

8.0.14 Setting and Participants

The playtest involved six senior debaters from the Jean Monet debate club in Bucharest, all aged between 18 and 20. These were experienced debaters, though none had encountered the Inside Out format before. I facilitated the session as the Evaluator and observed throughout.

8.0.15 The Brief

The brief took approximately 40 minutes. The format was significantly different enough from traditional debate that this length of explanation was necessary even for experienced players. Participants had many questions, particularly about two elements: (1) how the Subject role works and the roleplay dimension, which was described as “the newest and most different part of the format”, and (2) whether counter-argumentation between Value Defenders is permitted — a question I found somewhat surprising in hindsight.

8.0.16 Preparation Time

During prep time, the players struggled to figure out what to prepare. This was the first indication that the format demands a fundamentally different kind of preparation than traditional debate. Unlike preparing a policy or value case for traditional formats, players needed to figure out how to approach the Subject’s dilemma through the lens of a specific value.

8.0.17 Rituals

The roll-in rituals felt awkward and cringe to participants. The rituals themselves were lengthy and formalized, which created discomfort rather than appropriate atmosphere-setting. More effective would be a brief introduction by the Evaluator followed by a small gesture or shared chant that everyone performs together.

Notably, the players did recognize and appreciate that the rituals acknowledged the effort and role of the judge — in this case shared between the Evaluator and Subject.

The calling rituals (used to introduce each speaker) were received positively and did not require revision.

The roll-out rituals also felt overly lengthy and became cringe. However, one participant noted they appreciated the moment of collective gratitude that the rituals attempted to create. A simpler version involving handshakes and brief role-specific phrases would likely work better.

8.0.18 Speech Flow and Embodiment

An interesting pattern emerged across the speeches: players began using World Schools parliamentary plural and third-person references early on, but speech by speech, they naturally shifted toward second-person address and self-identification with the Subject’s values. One player would say “we believe” at the start of their first speech, but by the second round was saying “I believe in this value” and referring to the Subject directly as “you.”

This raised an important design question: should the Value Defenders fully embody the voice of the value (speaking as if they are an inner voice of the Subject themselves), or should they position themselves as advisors speaking about the Subject in the second person? The natural drift toward the former suggests players intuitively moved toward stronger roleplay embodiment, but the rules should be clarified on this point.

8.0.19 First Round of Value Defenders

Players immediately grasped that they needed to argue for the importance and relevance of their assigned value to the dilemma. They picked up on the fact that the solutions offered could be complex, realistic, and nuanced — distinct from traditional debate solutions.

However, the distinction between arguing for a value and proposing a decision remained fuzzy for many. The fact that they must “pick a solution and not necessarily a value” was confusing initially; the rules require clarification and possibly example mini-speeches illustrating this distinction.

8.0.20 Argumentation Style

The format demands a form of argumentation that is fundamentally different from traditional debate. Rather than constructing large-scale causal chains and impact scenarios, Value Defenders must argue for their values on their own terms — their importance, their weight in the decision, their interaction with other values. This was hard for players: it is uncommon in World Schools or BP debate, and finding “more things to say” about values themselves (as opposed to practical outcomes) required a different cognitive mode.

One significant observation: players felt the Subject character needed to be more fully fleshed out. The richer the characterization — the beliefs they hold, decisions they have made in the past, their personality — the easier it would be for Value Defenders to construct arguments tailored to that specific person’s identity and narrative consistency. Players noted that this reflects how people actually construct their own identities: by looking at the coherence of their past actions and trying to remain narratively consistent.

8.0.21 Participant Experience

Despite the challenges, or perhaps because of them, participants reported the format to be surprisingly liberating. They reported feeling “a lot less anxiety” than in traditional debate, while also finding the work “actually very complex and interesting strategically.” They noted that architecting solutions was intellectually demanding in a different way: every detail of the context became potential argumentative material rather than merely setting for claims about large-scale consequences.

One highly competitive player — the type that “usually wins a lot at competitions” — reported finding the format less exhilarating. They felt that the cooperative nature took away from the “thrill of collegial competitive jabbing” and the “adrenaline of winning,” making the overall experience feel “anticlimactic.” This was a useful signal: the format appears to function as an alternative to traditional debate rather than a replacement, appealing to different motivations than ego-driven competitive success.

8.0.22 Recognized Format Distinctiveness

Players articulated several ways in which the format plays differently:

- Explaining long, mechanistic causal chains is less necessary because there is no need to think through large-scale consequences (though such thinking could still occur if the dilemma involved someone with power over others).
- The power to formulate solutions makes it easier to stay topical and makes the whole debate less vague — the debate becomes about real dilemmas rather than abstract policy positions.
- It is less about proving large-scale third-order impacts and more about navigating genuine tensions between values.

Players reported speaking more slowly but with similar theatricality to traditional debate, contrary to expectations. Though some initially felt they spoke more monotonously, other participants who reported understanding that the Subject could be emotionally moved as well noted they were quite theatrical and expressive. Some said that were they to debate again, they would try to be more emotionally immersed, consciously shifting away from trying to be very “sweaty” toward winning.

8.0.23 Reported Learning and Growth

When asked what they believed they had learned, participants identified several insights:

- The format teaches you to be more relaxed and to enjoy playing.
- It teaches you to think about the context of decisions rather than abstractly applying rules.
- It makes you more human and more honest about human nature.
- It engages with the identity of decision-making: the recognition that “every team says valuable stuff and it is important more rather to see what is important to us.”
- This last point led to a striking reflection: that sometimes decisions are not universal, they are personal, and arguing that someone is morally wrong when deciding or believing something is a bit absurd.

Some participants felt the format is more suitable for beginners than for highly competitive debaters. I agree with the latter assessment but also believe that with a more complex motion, experienced debaters could recognize how the format could be played at higher skill levels.

8.0.24 Participant Feedback on Rules

Many participants requested the addition of Points of Information (POIs) — brief interjections during speeches. This became a high-priority feature request.

The participants also noted that the Subject role needs explicit scaffolding during preparation time. Rather than leaving this open, it would be helpful to have them prepare a first speech in which they explain the dilemma, why it is so hard, and how all values are relevant. Giving the dilemma “real gravitas” — proving to everyone that the decision is truly important and truly hard — would set the stage more effectively.

8.0.25 Observational Notes and Design Recommendations

Several design improvements emerged from observation:

- **Ritual for calling people:** A more natural, shorter ritual is needed between speeches to call in the next speaker.
- **Subject preparation:** Give the Subject team something concrete to do during prep time: prepare a first speech that explains the dilemma and its difficulty, establishing that all values are genuinely relevant.
- **Motion design:** Include a longer list of things the Subject believes about themselves and decisions they have made in the past. This supports more specific, character-tailored argumentation by the Value Defenders.
- **Speech instructions:** Make explicit instructions clearer, particularly on the distinction between defending a value and proposing a solution, and on whether Value Defenders should embody an “inner voice” of the Subject or position themselves as advisors.
- **Interstitial speech:** Consider whether an interstitial speech between the first and second rounds of Value Defenders might help reset the debate or provide needed structure. (This was later addressed in subsequent iterations by introducing the Huddle.)

Annex G — Second Playtest Report

The following is a first-person account of the second playtest session, held in April 2026. The session gathered seven veteran debaters. Design changes arising from this playtest are documented separately in Annex H.

8.0.26 Setting

I held the second playtest together with seven veteran debaters, close friends. We held it at the apartment that part of us commonly rent and share with other nerds for the single purpose of playing TTRPGs there. Because of that, the main room is dominated by a hilariously large, roughly round table. We held the debate seated at it, which one player noted created a council-feel to the whole session — as opposed to a regular debate in which the seating mimics parliamentary discourse and thus feels profoundly more impersonal. I was not the Evaluator this time; I played as the second speaker of the A Inner Voice team.

8.0.27 The Brief

The brief took about 40 minutes — similar to how much it took with the high-schoolers. The fact that it required that amount of time even with people accustomed to parsing lengthy rulebooks speaks to how much the design differs from traditional formats. The division of the “judge” role into two separate individuals (the Subject and the Evaluator) was noted as interesting by several players. The role of the Subject was by far the hardest for players to understand, especially the purpose of the opening Subject speech. I had, at the point of writing the rules, found it genuinely difficult to pin down what the Subject should do in that first speech. I wrote vague guidelines — and this showed — but in the end I believe it was for the better: I let the player decide what would be most interesting and useful. In that I was fortunate: the role was drawn by a player with substantial game-design experience, a professional L&D background, many years as a trainer, and deep experience as a roleplayer.

8.0.28 Rituals

The roll-in rituals were experienced as cringe, and were surely too lengthy. Players felt they should be replaced by a short introduction from the Evaluator followed by a brief shared gesture or chant. This aligns with how regular debates open: the judge makes an introduction, then everyone bangs the table vigorously and the debate begins. One player noted that the rituals do recognise the effort put in by the judge — in this case shared between the Subject and the Evaluator.

The calling rituals were received positively.

The roll-out rituals were also too lengthy and became cringe, but one player noted they liked the way in which people express gratitude to everyone. The consensus was that this could be replaced by a moment of handshakes in which each person says a short phrase based on their role. Players also noted that calling a defender by name during the calling ritual felt unnecessary.

8.0.29 S0 — The Opening Subject Speech

The player who drew the Subject role delivered an interesting, roleplay-heavy speech — they even played a soundtrack. They fleshed out the motion with many evocative details that further emotionally contextualised the scenario, then tried to explain how they care about all three values and why each is relevant to the decision. This in part exposed some nuanced personal biases that bled from the player into the character. Several players — including that player — noted that this institutionalises the already existing practice of debaters “playing for the judge”: attempting to exploit the judge’s known biases. I found this observation striking. The speech, although I was sceptical of it initially, does hold a great deal of value: fleshing out the scenario, giving a floor for surfacing biases. What it needs is clearer language for what players are supposed to do.

8.0.30 First Round of Inner Voices

All players immediately adopted a roleplay stance. They spoke directly to the Subject, addressing them by name and in the second person, looking at them, and choosing speech patterns that mirrored those the Subject had displayed. They also took the liberty to add small details to the motion — to worldbuild.

I find this very promising but also somewhat concerning. Giving players unofficial world-building powers may lead inexperienced players to twist the debate in an unhelpful direction. However, adding colour to the broad facts of the scenario does lend to a more realistic simulation of how people actually argue, raises emotional engagement, and heightens immersion.

It was interesting that even very veteran debaters struggled, especially in this first round, to both appeal to emotion and to argue specifically for their assigned value. Most focused on constructing interesting and nuanced Solutions and arguing why these were practical and useful — utilitarian and cerebral overall — except for the last team, who appealed explicitly to emotion, which set the tone interestingly for the second half.

Players also began referring to each other as “the other inner voices” — an organic renaming that feels more natural than “Value Defenders”. I plan to adopt it.

8.0.31 The Huddle

Everyone found the Huddle very, very fun. The Subject player later said it was a genuine eureka moment when they realised they could ask particular Inner Voices to have very specific conversations with each other. It is worth noting that this player has meeting facilitation experience. During the Huddle, the Subject first asked each team to clarify things they were still confused about, then asked teams to expand on arguments they found particularly interesting, then asked pairs of Inner Voices to directly clash on issues they felt needed resolving.

At a certain point the Subject ran out of ideas for what to ask. I believe that with two players on the Subject team this would happen less frequently. Still, ten minutes felt too long — I would cut it to eight.

8.0.32 Second Round of Inner Voices

The Huddle exacerbated something that had already started in the first round: a slow drift toward consensus on what decision should be taken. The second round was much less about the practicalities of which decision is best, and much more about arguing which is the dominant lens through which the decision should be viewed.

My intuition is that something similar might happen with other groups, not only with veteran debaters.

During my own speech I also pivoted toward consensus on the right Solution. I did this because I found it interesting and novel — something regular debate never allows — and I wanted to see how it felt, to demonstrate that the rules permit it, and to explore whether I could deliberately fish for the “Brave Pivot” commendation. I found that I felt little need to rebut the points made by others; arguing for my lens and shifting focus felt like a more natural and persuasive strategy than attacking others, and I allowed myself to be openly persuaded by fellow Inner Voices on some points.

A fellow player later noted that in this format to outright attack what others say “feels wrong” — disrespectful and unnecessary — and that the format requires tact in how one goes about diminishing the relevance of another’s points.

8.0.33 Second Subject Speech

The Subject player structured their speech quite like a regular debate adjudication: they explained what they understood each Inner Voice team to have argued and how convincing each case was, then expressed the solution they had reached and what had factored most in their decision. They later said that during the first speech they were in more of a roleplay mindframe, but that as the debate progressed they transitioned more and more to feeling and thinking like a debate judge.

My intention had been for the second speech to remain somewhat more roleplay-ish — the Subject speaking about how something *felt* persuasive, being a bit less analytical. I am not sure whether adjusting the instructions is needed, or whether this was simply the style of this particular player.

8.0.34 The Evaluator Speech

The Evaluator gave insightful feedback on how each of us could have been more persuasive to a regular person. She then noted it was very difficult to find feedback to give, because the format does not specify clearly toward what educational objectives the feedback should be directed.

This raised a broader question I should think about more: traditional debate exists within a complex, organic constellation of clubs and competitions. Most people tell themselves they do debate to learn — critical thinking, public speaking — and trainers and judges tell themselves they are there to teach useful skills. In practice, my sense is that the circuit has a life of its own, and that people invest effort on either side mostly for the social reputation it yields.

How should this format be played? Who should facilitate it? Who is it for? What should it help participants achieve?

Another interesting suggestion was that a structure allowing the Evaluator to be more actively involved — to facilitate and give real-time feedback, to encourage players — would be useful. I tend to agree. Renaming the Evaluator “the Facilitator” might help signal this.

The Evaluator also said that awarding commendations was difficult, and that in a larger circuit it would become easier: she would not feel pressure to give everyone a commendation and would reserve them for truly outstanding moments. She added that once the commendations were memorised the system would feel much more organic than the numeric speech-point quantification that most traditional formats require of judges.

8.0.35 On Bleed

I decided to skip the final bleed-releasing ritual, expecting it would feel awkward. It was interesting, then, that even without it, one of the players spontaneously shared during a brief intermission that the debate had hit uncannily close to home: on the way to the session, a family member had asked them to testify for them in court, which they had found morally wrong.

8.0.36 On Commendations

There was substantial discussion about the commendation system. The more “gamer” of the players expressed that it scratches a “make a build” itch, but felt that commendations should carry some bonuses as well. They also raised the concern that players might start farming them — choosing to play in unusual ways simply to collect a specific commendation and “complete” a build.

8.0.37 Participant Feedback

Most players expressed that the game was quite fun and that they believed it would be enjoyable even outside a casual friends setting.

One noteworthy pattern in the feedback: women and players who had been less successful as traditional debaters said they strongly preferred this format. Men who had been highly successful debaters expressed finding it less exhilarating. One participant put it directly: “There are few things more ego-boosting than the feeling of total mind-domination that you get when you win a debate, and this cannot give you that.”

One point everyone agreed on was that the format is much less anxiety-inducing than regular debate, while still providing a structure for meaningful conversation — unlike open real-life discussions, where people tend to fight over talking space.

One player suggested that the format might benefit from transitioning more wholeheartedly toward improv theatre — becoming a roleplaying game without any performance-evaluation component. Another countered that there is value in the sense that you are always progressing, at least a little, with every debate.

Annex H — Inside Out Debate Format: Third Design Iteration

The third design iteration is based on observations and participant feedback gathered during the second playtest (April 2026). The changes below supersede the corresponding elements in the second iteration (Annex B).

8.0.38 Role Renaming

Value Defenders are renamed Inner Voices. This name emerged organically during the second playtest, when players began referring to each other as “the other inner voices”. It better reflects the roleplay-oriented nature of the format and the relationship between the Value Defender teams and the Subject.

8.0.39 S0 — Opening Subject Speech Instructions

The instructions for the opening Subject speech are revised to foreground the roleplay dimension:

Hold a monologue as if you are the character, alone in a place of comfort, speaking to yourself about the dilemma. Express why this decision is truly difficult and how much getting it right matters to you. Explain why each value is relevant to this decision, and how you cannot simply disregard any of them. Do not lean toward any decision yet.

8.0.40 The Huddle

The Huddle is shortened from 10 minutes to **8 minutes**.

8.0.41 S2 — Final Subject Speech Instructions

The instructions for the final Subject speech are revised to include emotional closure:

Synthesise all arguments and deliver a decision over a specific solution — a concrete course of action from those presented by the Inner Voices. Explain how everything in the debate contributed to this decision; leave nothing important out. Say why you feel this is the right decision, and how you now feel about making it.

8.0.42 Seating

A seating instruction is added: try to arrange chairs so that the Inner Voices and the Subject face each other. Inner Voices speak from where they sit, standing or seated. The Subject does the same. The Evaluator sits somewhere outside the main circle — present but out of sight, out of mind.

8.0.43 Specific Times

The following timing guidelines are provided:

- **Speaking times:** 5 minutes per speech.
- **Prep time:** 30 minutes for beginners or high-school debaters; 15 minutes for experienced adults.
- **Evaluator oral critique:** 10 minutes.
- **Evaluator-led debrief:** 15 minutes.

8.0.44 Rituals

The following rituals replace those described in the first design iteration (Annex A).

Rolling In.

1. **Evaluator opens** — The Evaluator says: *“You are here to decide together.”*
2. **All respond** — Everyone answers: *“Yes, we are.”* followed by shared clapping.

Calling an Inner Voice.

1. The Evaluator calls: *“Voice, speak for [Value].”*
2. The speaker **must begin their speech** with the words *“I will. . .”*

Rolling Out.

1. **Voices’ thanks** — Each Inner Voice says: *“Thank you for listening to me.”*
2. **Subject’s thanks** — The Subject says to the Inner Voices: *“Thank you for speaking your truth.”* The Subject then says to the Evaluator: *“Thank you for listening to me.”*
3. **Bleed check** — Everyone states their real name and how they feel right now. The Evaluator then leads a brief debrief.

8.0.45 Commendation System

The commendation system is updated with a tier structure governing how commendations are distributed:

- Every debater should receive at least one **T1 (Earned)** commendation per speech. At higher levels of play, T1 commendations carry less competitive weight but remain a baseline acknowledgement of participation.
- The Evaluator has a **limited pool of T2 (Strong) and T3 (Exceptional)** commendations to offer per debate. These are awarded in private.

- Some commendations may be **exclusive to specific Evaluators**, reflecting their expertise or perspective.
- Some rounds or competitions may designate a **featured commendation** — a particular commendation given special significance in that context.

8.0.46 Evaluator Instructions

The Evaluator role is reframed toward active facilitation:

- You are the **facilitator** of the entire event. Your primary job is for everyone to feel safe and to play to grow.
- Feel free to **intervene** when it feels natural. Encourage players when you think it is necessary. Gently redirect when someone may be making others uncomfortable. Invite players out of their comfort zone when you believe it is in their best interest. Be human; establish a relationship of trust and growth with the others.
- After the debate ends, **first facilitate a brief debrief** stemming from the bleed check moment, then transition to the oral critique.
- Prepare **potential debrief questions** whilst others are preparing for the debate. Debrief questions should *not* focus (as the oral critique does) on skill growth, but rather on **meaningful emotional growth and acceptance of others' realities**. Explore how debaters would act in a similar scenario and what their own values are regarding the values explored in the debate. When in doubt, use these two anchor questions: *“How important are these values for you?”* and *“Were you in a similar scenario, what other values would influence you?”*
- Open the oral critique with a **narrative of the debate** from your outside perspective: what each team did and how it all unfolded.
- Engage directly with each team: ask what they **felt they did well** and what they found difficult. Share your view and add your own observations.
- Ask each team what they want to **do better next time**, and give concrete advice on how to get there.
- Award at least one **T1 (Earned)** commendation per speech to every debater. Use your limited pool of **T2 (Strong)** and **T3 (Exceptional)** commendations sparingly — these are awarded in private.

Annex I: Clues from Playtests

The following catalogue is the output of the three-phase systematic analysis described in the Methods chapter: initial descriptive coding of field notes and debrief responses, comparative organization around continuity, difference, and novelty, and articulation of design principles connecting mechanics to observed effects.

Unlike a traditional results catalogue, which reports only what happened, this annex is organized around a pre-defined taxonomy of *potential clues*: the observable signs that would count as evidence *for* or *against* the format's intended effects across each evaluation field. This taxonomy was specified *before* data collection, as described in the Methods chapter, to ensure that analysis remained responsive to disconfirming evidence and did not converge only on confirming observations. For each potential clue, the catalogue records whether it was observed during the playtests, with what evidential support, and at what strength. Clues that did not manifest are recorded explicitly: the absence of a negative clue is evidence of the format functioning as intended; the absence of a positive clue is a genuine gap.

Evidence is classified by direction and strength. **Positive clues** are behaviors or reports consistent with the format achieving its intended effect. **Negative clues** are behaviors or reports indicating a design gap or failure. Strength is assessed as *Strong* (behavioral, multi-source, or unsolicited), *Moderate* (self-reported or single-source), or *Weak* (speculative or highly context-dependent). Consistent with the comparative analysis described in the Methods chapter, behavioral and emergent evidence carries more weight than self-reported responses, and novel or different behaviors (departures from standard debate practice) constitute stronger design evidence than continuities, which may reflect participants' existing training rather than effects of the new format. Self-reported evidence gathered in response to direct questions in the semi-structured group debrief is noted where relevant, as it remains evidentially valid even if weaker than unsolicited or behavioral clues.

Sources: P1 = First playtest field notes (Jean Monet debate club, March 2026); P2 = Second playtest field notes (April 2026); D1/D2 = Post-session debrief responses after first/second playtest; T2 = Transcript of second playtest.

A note on social desirability in Field 1. Engagement and popularity clues are the most susceptible to social desirability effects: participants knew they were playtesting a format designed by the researcher in the room, and the exclusive nature of the invitation may have elevated their investment in displaying enthusiasm. Positive engagement evidence should therefore be read with additional skepticism; behavioral indicators are weighted higher than self-reports, and negative clues, which participants would have had more reason to suppress, carry elevated weight when they do appear.

Field 1: Engagement, Appeal, and Long-Term Viability

Positive potential clues

1. Unsolicited expressions of enthusiasm during or after the debate

Points toward: Positive affective engagement; potential for voluntary repeated participation.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Participants described the experience as “surprisingly liberating” (P1, D1) and “very very fun” during the Huddle phase (P2, D2). Multiple unprompted positive comments recorded in both debrief forms without being solicited.

Mechanic: Removal of binary win/loss outcomes, combined with out-of-sight Evaluator seating, reduces performance-oriented anxiety; personal dilemma motions create genuine stakes without threatening social standing, making organic enthusiasm more likely.

Strength: Moderate. Self-reported; subject to social desirability effects; see caveat above.

2. **Passionate or animated discussion among participants without researcher prompting**

Points toward: Genuine peer engagement; format generates internal conversational momentum.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2).

Evidence: Post-debrief conversation in both sessions extended organically beyond the structured questions. In the second playtest, participants continued discussing the motion and their own values informally after the session ended. Both sessions also produced animated group conversations specifically about the experience of using second-person direct address and personal appeals during speeches: participants in both groups noted that this mode of speaking (addressing the Subject directly as “you” and appealing to their personal circumstances) felt novel, engaging, and surprisingly enjoyable to both perform and receive.

Mechanic: Personal dilemma motions make participants’ own values directly relevant, creating natural grounds for continued conversation; the debrief structure designates and legitimizes extended reflection rather than truncating it. The second-person address mode inverts standard debate’s impersonal register, making the emotional texture of the debate itself a topic of enthusiastic reflection.

Strength: Moderate. Observed; behavioral; but also consistent with social novelty of the event.

3. **Visible engagement signals during debate itself (laughter, focused silence, forward leaning)**

Points toward: Format sustaining in-the-moment attention and flow.

Observed: Yes (P1 and P2).

Evidence: Second playtest field notes record observable engagement during speeches and very novel and creative decisions: to play background music during S1 speech, to adopt speaking accents etc. In the first playtest, as players became more aware of what they could do in the debate, they started to have more fun and more passionate speeches.

Mechanic: The Huddle phase builds emotional investment before speeches begin through interactive preparation; the Subject as a live, named decision-maker provides a concrete human target rather than an abstract adjudicator, sustaining speaker investment.

Strength: Moderate. Observational; first-playtest engagement was inconsistent.

4. **Unprompted recognition of the format’s benefits**

Points toward: Participants forming their own positive evaluation independent of researcher framing.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Multiple participants articulated benefits spontaneously: accessibility, empathy development, skill transfer, reduced anxiety. In the second playtest, there was conversation on how the format would be a useful personal development tool for “corpo trainings.”

Mechanic: Not tied to one particular mechanic but rather the format as a whole.

Strength: Moderate. Self-report; theoretically coherent; partially behavioral (the personal-development-tool framing implies intention to act).

5. **Expressed desire to replay or requests to organize future rounds**

Points toward: Replayability; format generates sustained rather than one-off interest.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1).

Evidence: Participants said they would play again and would aim to be “more emotionally immersed” next time (P1, D1). In the second playtest players reported they would find it a fun game especially to play with friends, as a passtime, and to get their “build” done.

Mechanic: The roleplay dimension of the format (emotional inhabitation of a character’s values) is recognized by participants as an unexplored skill, creating an intrinsic learning arc; the commendation system provides named targets (e.g., “Believable Passion”) for improvement across sessions.

Strength: Moderate. Self-reported intention; actual re-engagement behavior untested.

6. **High enjoyment scores when directly asked**

Points toward: Positive affective engagement; format generating a genuinely enjoyable experience rather than merely tolerable or dutiful participation.

Observed: Yes (D1, D2).

Evidence: When asked directly in the debrief form how much they enjoyed the game, participants in both sessions reported very high scores. While solicited self-report is weaker evidence than unsolicited enthusiasm, the consistently high numbers across both groups, including participants who were not particularly enthused about other aspects, indicate that the enjoyment response was not merely social desirability but genuine. The convergence with unsolicited expressions in clue 1 above strengthens the overall picture.

Mechanic: Same as clue 1.

Strength: Moderate. Direct debrief form response; subject to social desirability effects; convergent with unsolicited expressions.

Negative potential clues

1. **Taciturn, flat, or deflated behavior after the round**

Points away from: Engagement and emotional investment; would suggest the format failed to generate genuine stakes.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. Post-round behavior in both sessions was animated and conversational.

Strength: N/A.

2. **Direct criticism of the format itself**

Points away from: Overall appeal; structural design coherence.

Observed: Partially (P1, D1).

Evidence: The commendation system was criticised as “overwhelming” and difficult to use, particularly the size of the badge list (P1, D1). This was a targeted structural criticism rather than a wholesale rejection. The issue of commendation size was not directly addressed by a design change; it is to some extent intrinsic to the system. However, participants recognized that cognitive load would decrease with familiarity: as an Evaluator learns the commendation list over repeated use, the overhead diminishes naturally. Participants also noted that a practical workaround is available from the start: an Evaluator can simply observe what debaters do well in their speeches and work backwards to identify which commendation matches, rather than scanning the list prospectively. This makes the system more accessible at small scale than it first appears.

Mechanic: The commendation list in the first design iteration (Annex A) was designed for tournament scale, where Evaluators memorize a limited set of commendations over repeated use; at small informal scale with an unfamiliar system, the cognitive overhead of tracking all options exceeded what the context could support. The issue is thus primarily one of onboarding rather than structural incoherence.

Strength: Moderate. Specific and actionable; confined to one subsystem; not generalized to the format overall; partially mitigated by intrinsic learning curve and retrospective matching strategy.

3. **Visible loss of focus or disengagement during speeches**

Points away from: Sustained attention; flow state during play.

Observed: Partially (P1).

Evidence: One participant appeared uncertain about what to do during the Subject role in the first playtest, producing visibly hesitant behavior. This was role-confusion-driven rather than disengagement with the format broadly, and was not repeated in the second playtest.

Mechanic: The S0 and S1 instructions in the first design iteration did not specify the Subject’s active task during other teams’ speeches, leaving the Subject without a clear role during the middle of the debate.

Strength: Weak. Single instance; role-specific; addressed in next design iteration.

4. **Expressed preference for returning to standard competitive debate**

Points away from: Standalone appeal; would suggest format is only tolerable as an alternative, not as a preferred experience.

Observed: Partially (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: Across both playtests, a total of three participants (one in the first session and two in the second) expressed reservations tied to the format’s non-competitive

structure. All three were men who had been highly competitive and quite successful in traditional debate. In the first session, one participant described the format as “anticlimactic” and expressed missing the “ego-boosting” feeling of decisive victory (P1, D1); several others in that session suggested the format might be “easier” or “for beginners,” raising concern it could be perceived as less serious by the broader debate community. In the second session, in addition to similar sentiments, one participant raised a more structural concern: that the format’s apparent benefits might be partly an artifact of playing without an established meta: as a meta develops around Inside Out (as it has in World Schools and BP), the same competitive pressures and strategic distortions that the format tries to eliminate could re-emerge. This is a theoretically significant observation worth tracking in future iterations.

Mechanic: The removal of binary win/loss outcomes and zero-sum scoring is a deliberate design choice; these negative responses confirm that mechanic is operating as designed, not malfunctioning. The format is not intended to serve this participant profile as a primary audience, though the meta-concern raised in D2 is a genuine design question about long-term robustness.

Strength: Moderate for scoping the target audience; weak as evidence of a format-wide problem. The meta-concern is Weak at this stage (speculative, without empirical basis) but theoretically interesting.

5. “Cringe” reactions to ritual elements or format conventions

Points away from: Immersive design; willingness to engage with the format’s fictional premise.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: The ending ritual (Rolling Out) was described by participants as “very robotic” and as something that “takes you out of the immersion” (P1, D1). This reaction recurred in the second playtest: participants were observed mumbling the scripted phrases rather than delivering them with investment, and the researcher (as designer) was asked by participants to justify the purpose of the ritual phrases, an indication of a breakdown in the fictional frame (P2, D2). This is the strongest negative engagement clue from either playtest. It indicates that immersion *was* present before that point (participants could be “in the story”) but was disrupted by the ritual structure. The ritual was redesigned in the third design iteration (Annex H); the revised version has not yet been tested.

Mechanic: The first-iteration Rolling Out ritual required all participants to recite identical scripted phrases (“Thank you for listening to me,” “Thank you for speaking your truth”), producing a collective recitation effect (uniform, simultaneous, formulaic) incompatible with the personal and emergent character of the rest of the format.

Strength: Strong. Multi-session; multi-report; behavioral disruption (mumbling, questioning designer); design response drafted but untested.

Field 2: Productive Pressure Mechanisms

Positive potential clues

1. Visibly high engagement and effort during speeches

Points toward: Cognitive challenge retained; participants investing effort proportional to competitive formats.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, T2).

Evidence: In the second playtest, all Value Defenders immediately adopted elaborate roleplay stances (second-person address, emotional tone, worldbuilding detail) suggesting high rhetorical investment (P2, T2). The first playtest also showed high investment: participants came up with elaborate and nuanced solutions, constructed careful arguments, and several delivered quite passionate speeches, fully “try-hard” play despite the unfamiliar format (P1).

Mechanic: The format as a whole. Interaction mechanics in particular (the Huddle and Points of Information) were among the most liked and requested features across both playtests, suggesting they play an especially important role in sustaining engagement and effort.

Strength: Strong. Behavioral.

2. Strong performance quality: complex arguments, empathetic reasoning, strategic engagement

Points toward: Format generating the right kind of cognitive demand.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Participants described “architecting solutions” as “very complex and interesting strategically” (P1, D1). In the second playtest, participants navigated value hierarchies and inter-value tensions without prompting. The Subject’s S0 and S2 speeches in the second playtest demonstrated sophisticated contextual reasoning (T2). Both sessions also produced strikingly high levels of acting and roleplay: players adopted character mannerisms, delivered emotionally engaged speeches, and one played a background soundtrack during their S1. A key question raised in debrief was whether this emotional register came at the expense of critical thinking, but the evidence suggests it did not: very elaborate solutions, practicalities-based argumentation, and careful value hierarchies were consistently present, indicating that critical thinking and emotional engagement coexisted rather than traded off (P1, P2, T2).

Mechanic: The motion structure provides a specific character context that makes empathetic reasoning contextually available and strategically useful, rewarding perspective-taking as a competitive skill. Notably, the source of performance pressure shifts in this format: rather than the win/loss dynamic, the pressure becomes social: being recognized and appreciated by fellow Inner Voices and the Subject for the quality and resonance of one’s contributions. This social pressure is intrinsically tied to the quality of the engagement rather than to a binary outcome, making it a more nuanced and arguably healthier motivator.

Strength: Moderate. Partially self-report; partially observed; consistent across sessions.

3. Extensive post-debate reflection without researcher prompting

Points toward: Format generating cognitive and emotional residue worth processing.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Both debrief sessions extended well beyond structured questions. Participants in the first playtest returned to discussing the motion's dilemma long after the formal debrief. Participants in both sessions also discussed, with evident pride, how fun and interesting it had been to try out techniques that were new to them: the second-person address, the emotional appeals, the worldbuilding. This is a distinct form of reflection from dilemma-processing: it is reflection on craft and creative agency, suggesting the format activates not just cognitive and moral residue but performative pride in artistic experimentation.

Mechanic: The whole format; in particular, the open-ended character of the roleplay task provides room for genuine creative experimentation that standard debate's tight genre conventions do not.

Strength: Moderate. Observed; informally behavioral; consistent across both playtests.

4. **Expressed drive to improve; participants identifying their own growth edges**

Points toward: Format creating the kind of productive pressure that motivates development.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: Participants in the first session said they would aim to be “more emotionally immersed” on replay (P1, D1), identifying immersion as a dimension they had not yet mastered. In the second playtest, participants initiated a group conversation about a specific skill the format demands but they found difficult: being polite when doing counter-argumentation, navigating how to diminish the relevance of another Inner Voice's points without it feeling dismissive or adversarial (P2, D2). This reflects a more specific and format-native growth edge than emotional immersion, and was entirely self-identified. However, the very informal friends-hangout setting of the second session made the learning conversation less sustained and dynamic than it might have been in a more structured context; the topic was raised but not fully explored.

Mechanic: The commendation system names specific skills (e.g., “Believable Passion”) that participants can identify as aspirational targets; the roleplay dimension of the format provides a specific, named axis for development on replay that is recognized as distinct from standard debate skills. The polite counter-argumentation skill is format-specific: standard debate does not reward it, so recognizing it as a growth edge requires playing Inside Out.

Strength: Moderate. Self-report; forward-looking; actual improvement behavior untested. The P2 polite counter-argumentation conversation is particularly interesting as a format-native, self-generated growth goal.

Negative potential clues

1. **Apathy or minimal effort during speeches**

Points away from: Format generating meaningful productive pressure.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. All participants engaged substan-

tively with their speeches.

Strength: N/A.

2. Improvement discussion only when directly prompted by evaluator or researcher

Points away from: Intrinsic motivation to grow; would suggest format is experienced as externally evaluated rather than self-developing.

Observed: Partially (D1, D2).

Evidence: Some debrief forms contained brief or minimal self-improvement reflections that appeared to be prompted rather than unprompted. However, other responses in both sessions were substantive and self-initiated. The pattern is inconclusive.

Strength: Weak. Inconclusive; mixed within both debrief sets.

3. Confusion about what to do within role; confusion about how to improve

Points away from: Immediate accessibility; clear pressure architecture.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2).

Evidence: In the first playtest, the Subject player described not knowing “what to say” or how to “play very clean,” uncertain how to hold both emotional investment and evaluative neutrality simultaneously (P1, D1). In the second playtest, the Subject ran out of prepared Huddle questions before the 10 minutes elapsed (P2), revealing that the role requires more scaffolding than the ruleset provided. Both gaps were addressed in the second design iteration.

Mechanic: The S0 speech instructions in the first iteration did not specify the Subject’s emotional register or clarify the relationship between roleplay inhabitation (appropriate in S0/S1) and evaluative synthesis (appropriate in S2); the Huddle preparation time did not scaffold the kinds of questions the Subject should prepare. Both gaps were directly addressed in the second design iteration’s revised Subject role instructions.

Strength: Strong as a design-gap indicator. Behavioral; multi-instance; directly theoretically informative.

Field 3: Growth Direction, Useful Skills and Perspectives

Positive potential clues

1. Novel play patterns transferring real-world skills (empathy, contextual reasoning, negotiation)

Points toward: Format’s procedural rhetoric successfully encoding and transmitting its intended skill set.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2, T2).

Evidence: In the second playtest, all Value Defenders spontaneously adopted second-person address, direct eye contact with the Subject, and contextualizing worldbuilding details, none of which were instructed in the ruleset (P2, T2). In the first playtest, participants articulated learning to “think about the context of decisions” and to be

“more human and more honest about human nature” (P1, D1). One participant noted the format develops “conversational skills and empathy without necessarily having this educational background” (P2, D2). Three additional novel play patterns are worth noting: (1) a consistently *polite and collaborative form of counter-argumentation* emerged organically: players shifted focus rather than attacked, built on others rather than dismantling them, and recognized that outright rebuttal felt “wrong” in this context; (2) participants in the second playtest spontaneously moved toward *alignment on a common solution* across the second round of speeches, a behavior directly inverse to standard debate and a paradigmatic instance of the format’s procedural rhetoric encoding collaborative negotiation; (3) a *push toward synthesis* was evident in both rounds, with players building on rather than contradicting prior contributions, mirroring the kind of constructive dialogue the format is designed to develop.

Mechanic: The character assignment system (“you represent the Subject’s value of X”) and the personal dilemma motion structure (providing a named character with specific circumstances) invite perspective-taking without instructing it; the Subject as a named individual rather than an abstract adjudicator provides a concrete human recipient for empathetic reasoning. The absence of a rebuttal-rewarding scoring category inverts the rhetorical incentive structure, making polite, collaborative, synthesis-oriented engagement strategically advantageous rather than weakly punished.

Strength: Strong. Behavioral for second playtest; self-report for first playtest; consistent direction.

2. Continuation of standard debate’s positive skill patterns (research, structured argumentation)

Points toward: Format building on rather than displacing existing debate skills.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2).

Evidence: Participants continued to employ structured argument construction and research-based reasoning within speeches. The format did not produce a drift toward purely emotional or anecdotal argument; the value-argumentation task retained intellectual rigor.

Mechanic: The speech order (A1, B1, C1, S1, A2, B2, C2, S2) preserves the argument-sequencing logic of standard debate; the value-argumentation task still rewards research and logical structure, redirected toward value priority rather than policy consequence chains.

Strength: Low. Observational; consistent across both playtests, but it may be due more to the profile of the participants as experienced debaters.

3. Good play (empathetic, collaborative, value-aware) visibly rewarded in Subject Speech, Oral Critique, and debrief

Points toward: Evaluative culture aligned with transformative design intent.

Observed: Partially (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: Evaluators acknowledged empathetic and value-aware play in both oral critiques. Both playtest oral critiques were very insightful and offered meaningful feedback that rewarded good play. However, in both playtests Subject decisions did more rather reward overly-analytical play, but that points more towards the profile of the

participants as highly experienced debaters.

Mechanic: The oral critique provides a structured feedback channel explicitly tied to the evaluator’s observations; the commendation system names specific skills to reward. Both mechanisms are directionally correct but depend on evaluator familiarity with the system, which is immature at small scale.

Strength: Moderate. Partially implemented; evaluative culture immature at small scale.

Negative potential clues

1. Non-standard behaviors being rewarded that do not transfer real-world skills

Points away from: Skill development value; would suggest format incentivizes play that is idiosyncratic to Inside Out rather than transferable.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. No evaluator praise for behaviors inconsistent with empathy, contextual reasoning, or collaborative discourse was recorded.

Strength: N/A.

2. Emergence of unhelpful new play patterns (e.g., hollow performative emotionality without substance)

Points away from: Skill transfer; would suggest format’s emotional register invites performance rather than genuine reflection.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. Emotional engagement observed in both sessions was substantively connected to argument construction and scenario reasoning.

Strength: N/A.

3. Immersion-breaking format elements preventing the bleed arc from completing

Points away from: Memetic and emancipatory bleed; a truncated immersion arc limits transformative potential.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1).

Evidence: The ending ritual (Rolling Out) was experienced as “very robotic” and described as breaking immersion at the moment it was intended to complete the emotional arc (P1, D1). Because emancipatory bleed requires a sustained transformational container through closing, a ritual that breaks character at the end undermines the mechanism. This is the most significant growth-direction design gap identified.

Mechanic: The first-iteration Rolling Out ritual required participants to recite identical scripted phrases in sequence, producing a uniform collective-recitation effect incompatible with the personal and emergent character of preceding play. The ritual was redesigned in the third design iteration (Annex H); that revised version has not yet been tested.

Strength: Strong. Multi-report; behavioral disruption; theoretical mechanism clearly implicated; design response drafted but untested.

Field 4: Community Dynamics and Reduced Toxicity

Positive potential clues

1. Unsolicited expressions of safety and reduced anxiety

Points toward: Transformational container functioning; psychological safety achieved without sacrificing engagement.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: “Much much less anxiety-inducing than standard debate” was consistently reported across both playtests and multiple independent participants (P1, P2, D1, D2). Participants described the experience as “quieter, more rested” (P1) and noted a “feeling of salvation regardless of the result” (P2, D2). The consistency across two independent groups strengthens confidence in this finding.

Mechanic: Four mechanics operate jointly to reduce performance anxiety: (1) the Evaluator seating arrangement places the observer out-of-sight and peripheral, removing the primary anxiety-generating figure of standard debate; (2) no public scoring occurs during the round; (3) binary win/loss outcomes are removed, eliminating zero-sum social capital stakes; (4) the personal dilemma motion has no objectively correct answer, removing the possibility of being demonstrably wrong.

Strength: Very strong. Multiple independent reports; consistent across two sessions; theoretically predicted prerequisite for bleed.

2. Brave, vulnerable play acknowledged and rewarded

Points toward: Evaluative culture recognizing and incentivizing the emotional risk the format asks of participants.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: Multiple instances of brave and unconventional play were observed across both playtests. In the first session, the C team chose a deliberately vulnerable and conversational approach (emotionally intimate and unhurried) that is highly uncommon in the standard formats those participants were trained in; this was noted by others and acknowledged in the oral critique (P1, D1). In the second session, brave play took several forms: the S1 player chose to play a background soundtrack during their opening speech, a choice with no precedent in debate and a real social risk; the C team built their entire case around a worldbuilt character (the Subject’s mother) and her emotional stakes; players across the room adopted highly expressive, roleplay-heavy delivery styles; and participants responded to these choices with visible gesture-based approval and enthusiastic nonverbal acknowledgment throughout: laughing, nodding, leaning forward. The unplanned bleed event (a participant sharing privately that the scenario hit close to a real family situation) was also noted and acknowledged in the oral critique (P2, D2). Formal commendation assignment for brave play was not consistently enacted due to system immaturity.

Mechanic: The bleed-check moment in the third-iteration Rolling Out ritual explicitly creates a designated space for emotional acknowledgment; the Evaluator role instructions frame psychological safety as a primary responsibility, making responsive acknowledgment of vulnerable play structurally expected. The removal of win/loss outcomes reduces the cost of unconventional choices, making brave play a lower-risk

option.

Strength: Strong; multi-instance; behavioral; evaluative response was informal rather than systematic.

3. **Participants articulating liberation from standard debate’s performance pressure (emancipatory bleed)**

Points toward: Emancipatory bleed occurring: participants experiencing the format as freeing rather than constraining, and building confidence in their ability to speak up.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, D2).

Evidence: “More relaxed, not performing execrably, felt like playing really okay” (P1, D1); “gives a little feeling of salvation, regardless of the result” (P2, D2); “everyone distinguished himself by his own style, which in ordinary debate competitions does not happen” (P2, D2). These reflections articulate a liberation from the evaluative regime of standard debate, congruent with previously reported clues of an overall much lower level of anxiety experienced by all participants.

Mechanic: Character assignment externalizes personal value expression into a role (“I am arguing for the value of X”), reducing the social exposure of holding a minority position; the removal of binary outcomes eliminates the competitive cost of expressing an unconventional view; the personal style encouraged by the roleplay premise means individual expressiveness is rewarded rather than penalized.

Strength: Strong. Consistent across both playtests; multiple independently-worded formulations of the same attitudinal shift.

4. **Emergent norms of collaborative rather than adversarial discourse**

Points toward: Format’s procedural rhetoric successfully reshaping community conduct without explicit instruction.

Observed: Yes (P2, D2).

Evidence: Participants in the second playtest spontaneously articulated that “outright attacking others’ points feels wrong, disrespectful, and unnecessary.” This was not a rule in the format but an emergent norm arising from the format’s structure, a paradigmatic instance of procedural rhetoric in action. Players also noted that shifting focus and building on others’ contributions felt “more natural and more persuasive” than traditional rebuttal.

Mechanic: The Subject as shared persuasion target means all Value Defenders are competing for the same person’s attention rather than defeating each other; no scoring category rewards rebuttal specifically, meaning attacking a competitor’s argument carries no direct competitive benefit while building on it does, thus inverting the rhetorical incentive structure of standard competitive debate.

Strength: Strong. Behavioral; emergent; unsolicited; theoretically predicted.

Negative potential clues

1. **Expressions of distress during or after the round**

Points away from: Psychological safety; would suggest the format activates personal stakes without providing sufficient containment.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. The unplanned bleed event (participant sharing a real family situation) was handled calmly within the debrief structure; no distress was recorded. The bleed-check and debrief protocols appear to have functioned as intended.

Strength: N/A. Notable absence given the emotional intensity of some moments.

2. Arrogant, dismissive, or unempathetic behavior during debate

Points away from: Community health; toxicity reduction.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest. No dismissive or contemptuous behavior toward other participants was recorded in either field notes or transcripts.

Strength: N/A.

3. Such behavior being praised by the evaluator or community

Points away from: Evaluative culture aligned with design intent; would signal the format’s recognition system is rewarding the wrong behaviors.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest.

Strength: N/A.

Field 5: Epistemic Humility

Positive potential clues

1. Unprompted awareness that multiple competing perspectives hold genuine value

Points toward: Core attitudinal shift targeted by the format: epistemic humility arising from procedural engagement with value conflict.

Observed: Yes (P1, D1, P2, D2).

Evidence: “Every team says valuable stuff and it is important more to see what is important to us” (P1, D1). This formulation, articulated without prompting after a single encounter, captures precisely the attitudinal shift the design targets: moving from “which side is right” to “what do I value and why.” Additional supporting evidence from the first playtest includes participants articulating that arguing someone is “morally wrong” for their personal decisions feels “a bit absurd” in this context, and recognition that the format makes personal value priorities legible rather than evaluating them against an external standard (P1, D1). In the second playtest, a notable extended conversation emerged in the debrief about how the Subject’s opening speech (S0) institutionalises the practice of surfacing personal biases, making explicit what a player personally cares about before the debate even begins. Participants contrasted this with other formats, where the pretense of objectivity is maintained throughout: in those formats, they argued, biases are falsely supposed not to exist, propagating the idea that only one particular type of “objective” person can judge well and legitimizing social pressure to perform that identity. The S0 mechanism, by contrast, invites players to name their values openly from the start, reframing bias not as contamination

but as perspective (P2, D2).

Mechanic: The three-value motion structure assigns each team a value that is genuinely defensible for the character; the Subject’s final synthesis requirement frames the question as “what matters most to this person in this context” rather than “which position is objectively correct,” making all three perspectives legitimate from the outset. The S0 speech institutionalises bias transparency rather than suppressing it, which makes epistemic humility structurally available rather than personally effortful.

Strength: Moderate. Multi-session; self-report; directly on-target with design intent; P1 formulation notable for being unprompted; P2 debrief conversation particularly theoretically rich.

2. **Demonstrated understanding that personal values are context-dependent, not universal**

Points toward: Internalization of the format’s procedural rhetoric: that decisions are contextually embedded and legitimately vary by person and circumstance.

Observed: Yes (P1, P2, D1, T2).

Evidence: “Sometimes decisions are personal, not universal” (P1, D1). The Subject’s S0 and S2 arc in the second playtest demonstrated a similar trajectory: moving from roleplay inhabitation (personal, contextual) toward evaluative synthesis (what values do I hold about this?), with explicit self-awareness of that transition (P2, T2).

Mechanic: The character-specific motion context (personal history, relationships, circumstances) makes universal moral claims strategically inappropriate to the scenario; the S0 instructions ask the Subject to describe the scenario from a personal perspective before argumentation begins, embedding contextual reasoning before any abstract principle is introduced.

Strength: Moderate. Multi-session; self-report and behavioral; theoretical coherence strong.

3. **Spontaneous movement toward synthesis rather than competitive winning**

Points toward: Format orienting participants toward value integration rather than dominance: the deepest available behavioral indicator of epistemic humility in action.

Observed: Yes (P2, T2).

Evidence: In the second round and also less in the first one of Value Defender speeches, participants naturally moved toward synthesis rather than intensifying conflict, the reverse of what standard debate produces. This was not instructed; it emerged from the format’s procedural logic (P2, T2). Additionally, the Subject’s opening statement “I’m not sure if that’s the solution; that’s why this thing is eating at me” (P2, T2, transcript-confirmed) demonstrates genuine epistemic uncertainty from the start of the round, produced by the format’s demand that the Subject hold the dilemma rather than resolve it prematurely. Two further details reinforce this orientation toward collegiality and synthesis: (1) participants in the second playtest organically renamed themselves “Inner Voices” (which was subsequently formalized in the third design iteration), a label that positions them as parts of a shared internal deliberation rather than as opposing sides, colleagues rather than opponents; (2) the rules themselves permit multiple Inner Voices to argue for the same solution, structurally allowing con-

sensus rather than requiring disagreement, which removes the adversarial constraint that standard debate formats impose.

Mechanic: Speeches A2/B2/C2 are expected to build on A1/B1/C1 rather than dismantle competitors' positions. The Subject's S1 is an explicitly preliminary decision requiring ongoing engagement, structurally rewarding continued dialogue. The Huddle allows the Subject to ask clarifying questions, modeling collaborative inquiry as a legitimate competitive move. The Inner Voices naming and the same-solution permission together reframe competition from adversarial to collegial at the level of both identity and rules.

Strength: Strong. Behavioral; transcript-confirmed; emergent; theoretically predicted.

Negative potential clues

1. Unequivocal condemnation of beliefs or belief-holders

Points away from: Epistemic humility; would indicate the format is activating moral certainty rather than productive uncertainty.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest or in the transcripts. No unequivocal condemnation of a position, values system, or person was recorded.

Strength: N/A. Absence is notable given that the motions used both involved choices with genuine ethical weight.

2. Such condemnation being normalized or praised

Points away from: Community epistemic culture; would signal the format's evaluative frame rewards dogmatic certainty.

Observed: No.

Evidence: Not manifested across either playtest.

Strength: N/A.

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